

Union Square

The Palimpsest of Union Square's Northern Crown: An Architectural and Social Genealogy

Every previously italicized phrase is highlighted and colour-coded by source. Where the source page is on file, clicking the highlight opens the scan.

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Chase, <i>New York The Wonder City</i>, 1932 p. 198 (2) ↗	Bergman, <i>The Spiritual Traveler New York City</i>, 2001 p. 133 (1) ↗
Holmes, <i>100 New Yorker</i>, 2004 p. 168 (1) ↗	Lockwood, <i>Manhattan Moves Uptown</i>, 1976 pp. 167, 169, 178, 291 (16) ↗
St Louis, <i>Lonely Planet New York City</i>, 2016 p. 163 (4) ↗	Leadon, <i>Broadway A History of New York in Thirteen Miles</i>, 2018 p. 118 (3) ↗
Burrows & Wallace, <i>Gotham</i>, 1999 p. 869 (3) ↗	Unknown Author, <i>New York Illustrated</i>, 1876 p. 63 (3) ↗
Museyon Inc., <i>Art+NYC</i>, 2011 p. 208 (1) ↗	Alleman, <i>New York The Movie Lover's Guide</i>, 2005 p. 212 (1) ↗
Binkowski, <i>Musical New York</i>, 1999 p. 107 (1) ↗	LPC, <i>Union Square</i>, 1893 p. 1 (3)
WPA, <i>WPA Guide to NYC</i>, 1939 p. 203 (4) ↗	Hennessy, <i>Walking Broadway</i>, 2020 p. 97 (2) ↗
Postal & Dolkart, <i>Guide to New York City Landmarks</i>, 2009 p. 76 (2) ↗	Morrone, <i>Architectural Guidebook</i>, 1994 p. 116 (3) ↗
LPC, <i>Union Square</i>, 1903 p. 1 (2) ↗	Robinson, <i>1885 Robinsons Atlas</i> p. 15 (1) ↗
Wolfe, <i>New York 15 Walking Tours</i>, 2003 p. 249 (2) ↗	Reiss, <i>New York Then and Now</i>, 2019 p. 76 (1) ↗
Stern, <i>New York 2000</i>, 2006 p. 377 (3) ↗	LPC, <i>Union Square</i>, 1881 p. 1 (4) ↗
LPC, <i>Union Square</i>, 1908 p. 1 (3)	Watson & Gillon, <i>New York Then and Now</i>, 1976 p. 80 (1) ↗
Dolkart, <i>Gramercy</i>, 1996 p. 78 (4) ↗	Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i>, 2016 p. 679 (2) ↗
Kahn, <i>City Secrets New York City</i>, 2002 p. 189 (1) ↗	

AUDIO — UNION SQUARE | BRICK CAKE (MULTI ADDRESS) 22 min 36 s

Audio track — playable in the HTML version of this document.

GENESIS: FROM ALLUVIAL HILLOCK TO CIVIC COMMONS

Beneath the ordered geometry of the modern square lies a topography of pure accident. In its primordial state, *(Union Square was originally a sand hill. Had it not been for the sand, Irving Place & Lexington Ave. would likely be part of Broadway today!)* — a geological caprice that, in redirecting the city's northward march, quietly authored the very street grid we now take for granted. The nomenclature itself encodes a cartographic confluence, for *(Union Square took its name from the fact that it was the spot where the Bowery and*

Bloomingdale Road (today's Broadway) came together, that is, united.) Situated at this juncture of thoroughfares, *(The square marks the union of Fourth Avenue and Broadway and was saved from further development by the city in 1811.)*

The parcel's provenance is a chronicle of colonial-era conveyances. *(The land was once part of Elias Brevoort's farm, but in 1762 he sold twenty acres lying west of the Bowery Road, or Third Avenue, to John Smith, whose heirs subsequently sold it to Henry Spingler for \$4750.)* Municipal foresight then intervened, though with characteristic bureaucratic deliberation: *(In 1807 Broadway was regulated from Astor Place to the vicinity of Twenty-third Street, and in 1815 the city designated part of the land that became Union Square as a public park. The city, however, did not take title to Union Square or lay out the land as a park until 1831.)*

The rationale advanced for the acquisition betrays a shrewd anticipation of the speculative pressures to come. Municipal authorities reasoned that *(now that the ground is unoccupied, the purchase can be effected, which, in the lapse of a few years, when valuable buildings are erected, will be impracticable, on account of the great expense.)* Undergirding this fiscal prudence was a nascent theory of urban salubrity, the conviction that open ground furnished indispensable *(ventilators to a densely populated city.)* Thus was the commons conceived less as ornament than as civic respiratory apparatus.

The square's ascendancy to fashionable pre-eminence was foretold almost from its inception. *(With its enviable location at what was then the northernmost limit of Broadway and just half a mile north of stylish Bond Street, Union Square was assured of a fashionable destiny, predicted the Herald as early as 1836.)* The subsequent building boom proceeded at a velocity that astonished contemporaries, who marveled that *(Whole streets of magnificent dwelling houses have been erected in the vicinity of Union Square within the last year.)* The pivotal act of speculative release came when *(Palatial row houses and mansions began to rise, facing Union Square itself, after the Bank of Manhattan sold the lots it owned around the perimeter of the park in 1845.)* As mansions proliferated, the park was refined to complement its patrician setting, and *(the park was planted with lawns, flower beds, trees, and shrubbery. Gas street lights were installed by 1849.)*

THE BELLE ÉPOQUE OF THE SQUARE: SALON CULTURE AND GENTEEL REPOSE

In its meridian, the square constituted the acknowledged locus of metropolitan gentility. From its opening in 1831, *(Union Square quickly became the central gathering place for those who lived in the mansions nearby. Concert halls and artist societies further enhanced the cultured atmosphere, and high-end shopping quickly proliferated along Broadway, which was dubbed 'Ladies' Mile.)* So thoroughgoing was the exclusion of commerce from these precincts that a visitor could remark, of the residential streets to the north, that *(Not a store is to be seen...nothing but the dwellings of the aristocracy, who moved up here out of the noisy and dusty part of the city.)*

The neighborhood's mercantile ethos insinuated itself even into the park's most whimsical furnishings. The avian dwellings suspended in the trees were *(ingeniously contrived miniature buildings for these little birds, placed among the branches of the trees)*, and these confections were fashioned to *(represent different business departments as 'The Post Office,' 'The Custom House,' 'The Exchange,' etc.)* So relentlessly commercial was the surrounding sensibility that wags observed how *(even the neighborhood birds had to be busy at work all day long)* — a droll allegory of a moneyed class incapable of imagining leisure untethered from enterprise.

THE GREAT REVERSAL: TRADE ASCENDANT AND THE PATRICIAN EXODUS

The idyll proved evanescent. What *(shocked and upset the gentility in the 1860s was the influx of shops into Union Square. They took over the basements and parlor floors of mansions and row houses, some of which were less than ten years old, and none of them more than twenty years old.)* The tempo of transformation was such that, by mid-decade, *(the Times reported that nearly all the houses on Union Square had become boardinghouses.)*

Commerce advanced with an almost tidal inexorability, and *(the blocks surrounding the formerly tranquil square hummed with commercial activity, with once-grand mansions converted to boardinghouses, stores, and offices rented to chiropodists, coal dealers, dressmakers, milliners, hairdressers, furriers, and cloak manufacturers.)* The symbolic coup de grâce arrived when *(IN 1870, TIFFANY'S DEMOLISHED the James Renwick-designed Church of the Puritans on the west side of Union Square and replaced it with a huge cast-iron store—the "Palace of Jewels.")* — the supplanting of a sanctuary by a temple of luxury retail furnishing an almost too-perfect emblem of the age's transvaluation.

To dignify the increasingly commercial precinct, the municipality summoned the era's foremost landscape practitioners: *(In 1872 the city hired Calvert Vaux and Frederick Law Olmsted, designers of Central Park, to remake Union Square according to a more up-to-date, picturesque aesthetic.)* Meanwhile, spiraling valuations accelerated the flight of the old families, for by *(1866 and 1867, houses on Union Square were selling for \$125,000 to \$180,000, up from the \$15,000 that lots in the area had fetched ten or fifteen years earlier.)* — a twelvefold appreciation that rendered residential occupancy an act of economic irrationality.

THE THEATER OF THE REPUBLIC: RALLY, RITE, AND REMONSTRANCE

As its domestic character dissolved, the square assumed a grander vocation as the amphitheater of the body politic. In the crucible of civil conflict, *(Union Square would replace City Hall Park as the center of civic life.)* The most celebrated of its convocations unfolded in 1861, when *(what was reputedly the largest assemblage ever seen on the continent—somewhere between 100,000 and 250,000 people—flooded into Union Square.)*

On that consecrated occasion, *(The new bronze statue of Washington was wrapped in the flag that had been fired upon at Sumter)* — a gesture in which the relic of a besieged fortress and the effigy of the republic's founder were fused into a single patriotic tableau.

The square's identity as a forum of dissent proved durable across generations. With the outbreak of hostilities, *(the vast public space (large by New York standards, of course) was center stage for protesters of all sorts—from union workers to political activists.)* In the ensuing decades it became a magnet for the era's insurgent movements, drawing *(politically and socially driven organizations like the American Civil Liberties Union, the Communist and Socialist Parties, and the Ladies' Garment Workers Union to move in.)* By the interwar years its radical complexion was unmistakable, such that *(The Communists of New York make their headquarters at Union Square also.)*

33 UNION SQUARE WEST — THE DECKER BUILDING: ORNAMENTAL GOTHIC TO AVANT-GARDE ATELIER

At the square's northern flank stood an edifice whose successive incarnations trace the arc of the city's cultural history. Erected to house celebrated piano warerooms, it drew rhapsodic contemporary notice: *(But, of all our new buildings., the handsomest Is the one on Union Square, for Decker Brothers' piano warerooms. This building, though not large, is in a new direction in street-architecture, and we may well hope to sec its example followed. It is of Ohio freestone and brick, in the style known as the ornamental Gothic, and, with the contrasts of tints in the material and its quaint windows, makes a most picturesque effect.)*

The chronicler's enthusiasm swelled into a manifesto against the monotony of the prevailing idiom: *(One is so weary of brownstone, sandstone, white marble, and painted iron, in our architecture, that a front like this, so full of light and shadow, so mellow and rich in tone, so fresh and pleasing in design, is a very agreeable revelation. What a superb quarter of the city Union Square would be, if fronted with buildings as inspiring as this!)* The instruments crafted within secured the firm an international eminence, for *(The firm is one of the most prominent of representative piano-forte makers in the world, having won this proud position by the intrinsic merits of the instruments of its make.)*

In the fullness of time, the building was inducted into the annals of the postwar avant-garde. *(In 1968 Warhol moved downtown to the Decker Building, where he set up his White Factory. A stark contrast to the anything-goes vibe of the Silver Factory, Warhol's Union Square studio was set up like an office. It was here that he was shot by Valerie Solanas in July 1968.)* As a corollary account specifies, the artist's coterie migrated in early 1968 to *(the sixth floor of a ca. 1900 loft building at 33 Union Square West.)* By the close of the century, its origins as a musical enterprise survived only as elegiac memory: *(Only the Decker Piano Building remains (33 Union Square West). A beautiful architectural example of bygone times, its days as a piano firm are long gone,*

too.) The survey record consecrates its exotic idiom — a Moorish, Venetian composition wrought in (Brick, Limestone, Terra Cotta) and surmounted by a (Tile Roof) studded with (Islamic Star Roundels). The WPA corroborated this Orientalist flourish, noting that (at No. 33 the Union Building, built in 1893, has richly framed windows inspired by Spanish Moorish design.)

31 UNION SQUARE WEST — THE BANK OF THE METROPOLIS: TRIPARTITE RIGOR IN LIMESTONE

Adjacent stood a paradigm of financial architecture's studied gravitas. (The familiar, sober classical vocabulary of bank architecture is enlivened here by a welcoming two-story bowed portico supported by a pair of gray granite Ionic columns facing Union Square.) Nor was its longer elevation neglected, for (The long 16th Street elevation also features some distinctive touches.)

The institution was woven into the commercial fabric of the district from its founding, having been (founded in 1871 to serve the needs of businesses in the Union Square area, maintained its offices on the square until 1918, when it was absorbed by the Bank of Manhattan.) Its architect commanded particular distinction as (an important early skyscraper designer with a particular interest in adapting the tripartite form of the column to tall buildings) — a preoccupation legible in the building's disciplined base-shaft-capital articulation. Constrained by its lot, the structure presents a face of exceptional slenderness, for (Its Union Square front is extremely narrow.) The survey assigns its base the tone Coral Reef and its façade Pearl White, a marriage of (Rusticated Limestone, Granite Bulkheads, Polished Granite Columns) ascending to a (Limestone) shaft. The site had long served commerce, an 1885 atlas recording that at this address (there is written 'White Manfg.Co.')

33 EAST 17TH STREET — THE CENTURY BUILDING: QUEEN ANNE ERUDITION IN BRICK AND BLUESTONE

At the square's upper margin presides a redbrick monument to the golden age of American periodical publishing. (The red brick, Queen Anne-style structure is one of the finest examples of the style and was built to house the many publishing activities of the Century Company.) In an alternative appraisal it emerges as a (red-brick-and-limestone Queen Anne pile comes straight out of Victorian London), a transatlantic import so faithful that it ranks among (one of the few extant major Queen Anne buildings in Manhattan.)

The firm it sheltered commanded a distinguished catalogue, for (Among its imprints were the Century and St. Nicholas magazines and a host of fine books.) In the vernal flower markets that once animated the square, its bulk dominated the horizon, since (The large building in the background is the Century Company Building

Completed in 1881 on the north end of the square, it was first leased to the publishers of the popular *Century* and *St Nicholas* magazines.) Its architectural significance was ratified by its inclusion among the landmarked ensemble as *(the Century Building (William Schickel, 1881), 33 East Seventeenth Street.)* The survey records its base as Crystal and its façade as Brick Red, composed of *(Red Brick, Wyoming Bluestone)* at grade and *(Brick, Terra Cotta, Wyoming Bluestone, Iron)* above, crowned by a *(Gambrel Roof)* and ornamented with *(Sunflower Terra Cotta Finials)* — an Aesthetic Movement conceit rendered in fired clay.

45 EAST 17TH STREET — THE EVERETT BUILDING: CLASSICAL REVIVAL ON HALLOWED GROUND

Upon a site once graced by a celebrated hostelry rose a Beaux-Arts-inflected office block whose preservation reflected a broader vigilance. *(Concerns about the fate of historic buildings on other sites around the square led to the designation as landmarks of...the Everett Building (Starrett & Van Vleck, 1908), 45 East Seventeenth Street.)* The survey fixes its base at Antique Brass and its façade at Beige, executed in *(Terra Cotta, Marble)* at the base and *(Terra Cotta, Polychrome Terra Cotta)* across the elevation, in an idiom identified as *(Classical-Revival.)* The block bore an antecedent of renown, for *(The Everett House, completed in 1854, stood at 41 East Seventeenth Street, on the north side of the park)*; and, as a later observer recorded, *(The five-story building at the northwest corner of East 17th Street is the Everett House. Built in 1854, this hotel was convenient to 14th Street's shopping, musical and theatrical attractions.)*

1-3 UNION SQUARE WEST — THE LINCOLN BUILDING: ROMANESQUE GRAVITAS

Presiding over a further corner stood a Romanesque revival veteran. *(The Lincoln Building, erected at I Union Square in 1889, is an example adapted from Romanesque work.)* It too was accorded protection, enumerated among the landmarks as *(the Lincoln Building (R. H. Robertson, 1890), 1-3 Union Square West.)*

100-102 EAST 17TH STREET — TAMMANY HALL: THE ICONOGRAPHY OF LEGITIMACY

At the southeastern corner of 17th Street rose an edifice conceived as a rhetorical instrument of political rehabilitation. *(On the southeast corner of East 17th Street and Union Square East, at 100-102 East 17th Street, stands the second of the district's institutional buildings. Tammany Hall, once the headquarters of New York City's Democratic Party political machine.)* Its architectural vocabulary was deliberately declarative, presenting *(a dignified architectural treatment, one of the chief motifs of which are the severe Colonial columns in the centers of the Union Square and the Seventeenth-street facades which recall the days of early American architecture.)*

The stylistic choice was freighted with intention, for *(The Colonial Revival was undoubtedly chosen not only because it was reminiscent of the architecture of the early republic, but also because it symbolized the government established during that period.)* In effect, the organization pursued architectural absolution, since *(The Society of Tammany was attempting to associate itself with the ideals of early American democracy.)* Its material vocabulary reinforced the historicist argument: *(This distinguished neo-Georgian facade, with its rusticated stone base, double-height pilasters, and sculptural reliefs in terra cotta and limestone, was inspired by the original Federal Hall.)* The gambit was audacious given the institution's reputation, for *(Tammany Hall, now a byword for municipal corruption, once dominated the City's political arena)* — a machine that sought, through the borrowed dignity of Federal-era motifs, to launder its notoriety in the currency of republican virtue.

CODA: THE SQUARE AS ARCHITECTURAL PALIMPSEST

To traverse the northern crown of the square is to read a stratified text in masonry, each layer bearing witness to a distinct chapter of the city's self-invention. *(The diverse architecture of the buildings surrounding Union Square does not supply the unified feeling of enclosure implied by the word "square," but it does offer an interesting record of architectural styles that have been popular in past years.)* The commercial palaces share, for all their stylistic disparity, a governing compositional logic, whereby *(Three divisions of each facade are clearly marked: a base ornamented with classical details, an intermediate portion of undecorated masonry pierced by regular windows, and a crowning element at the top consisting of arched windows and an elaborate cornice.)*

The square endures as a repository of improbable heterogeneity, a place *(like the Noah's Ark of New York, rescuing at least two of every kind from the curling seas of concrete.)* For the discerning peripatetic, the counsel remains as apt as ever: *(The trick to any stroll through this zone is to look up. Each building brings an animated story to the streetscape, and many have been lovingly restored and given meaningful, modern uses.)*



CITATION CHART

Every highlighted quote, in order of appearance, correlated to its underlying source. The swatch matches the highlight colour in the text.

Genesis: From Alluvial Hillock to Civic Commons

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The Belle Époque of the Square: Salon Culture and Genteel Repose

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The Great Reversal: Trade Ascendant and the Patrician Exodus

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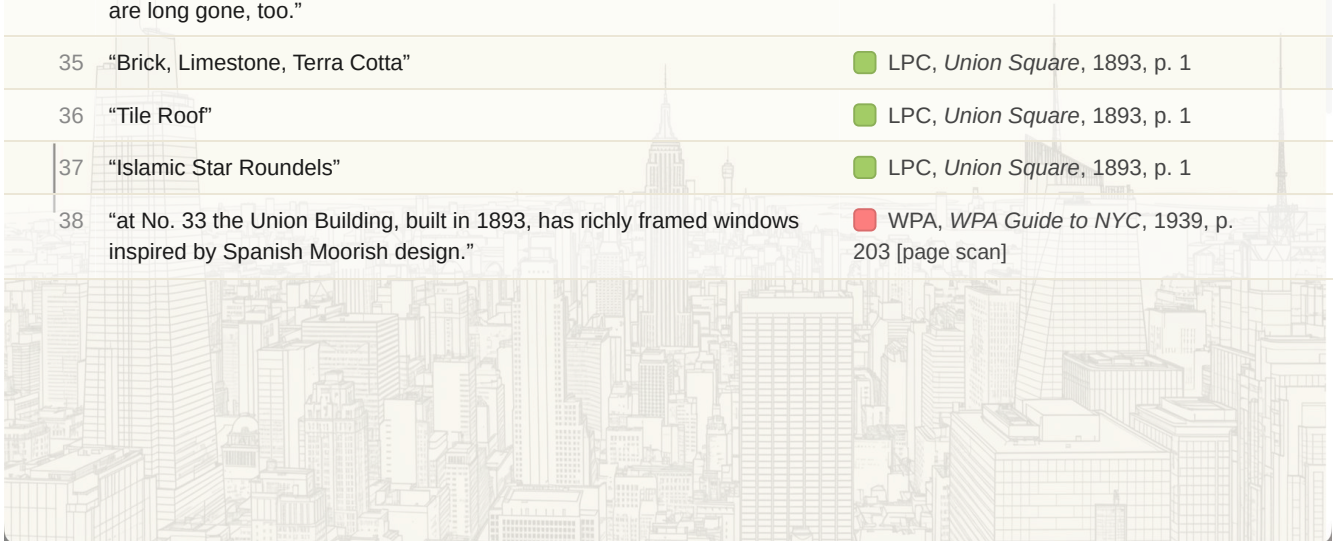
The Theater of the Republic: Rally, Rite, and Remonstrance

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33 Union Square West — The Decker Building: Ornamental Gothic to Avant-Garde Atelier

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35	"Brick, Limestone, Terra Cotta"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1893, p. 1
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38	"at No. 33 the Union Building, built in 1893, has richly framed windows inspired by Spanish Moorish design."	 WPA, <i>WPA Guide to NYC</i> , 1939, p. 203 [page scan]



31 Union Square West — The Bank of the Metropolis: Tripartite Rigor in Limestone

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50	"Among its imprints were the Century and St. Nicholas magazines and a host of fine books."	 Wolfe, <i>New York 15 Walking Tours</i> , 2003, p. 249 [page scan]
51	"The large building in the background is the Century Company Building Completed in 1881 on the north end of the square, it was first leased to the publishers of the..."	 Reiss, <i>New York Then and Now</i> , 2019, p. 76 [page scan]
52	"the Century Building (William Schickel, 1881), 33 East Seventeenth Street."	 Stern, <i>New York 2000</i> , 2006, p. 377 [page scan]
53	"Red Brick, Wyoming Bluestone"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
54	"Brick, Terra Cotta, Wyoming Bluestone, Iron"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
55	"Gambrel Roof"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]
56	"Sunflower Terra Cotta Finials"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1881, p. 1 [page scan]

45 East 17th Street — The Everett Building: Classical Revival on Hallowed Ground

#	Verbatim Quote (abbreviated)	Source (Author, Title, Year, Page)
57	"Concerns about the fate of historic buildings on other sites around the square led to the designation as landmarks of...the Everett Building (Starrett & Van Vleck,..."	 Stern, <i>New York 2000</i> , 2006, p. 377 [page scan]
58	"Terra Cotta, Marble"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1908, p. 1
59	"Terra Cotta, Polychrome Terra Cotta"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1908, p. 1
60	"Classical-Revival."	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1908, p. 1
61	"The Everett House, completed in 1854, stood at 41 East Seventeenth Street, on the north side of the park"	 Lockwood, <i>Manhattan Moves Uptown</i> , 1976, p. 291 [page scan]
62	"The five-story building at the northwest corner of East 17th Street is the Everett House. Built in 1854, this hotel was convenient to 14th Street's shopping, musical and..."	 Watson & Gillon, <i>New York Then and Now</i> , 1976, p. 80 [page scan]

1-3 Union Square West — The Lincoln Building: Romanesque Gravitas

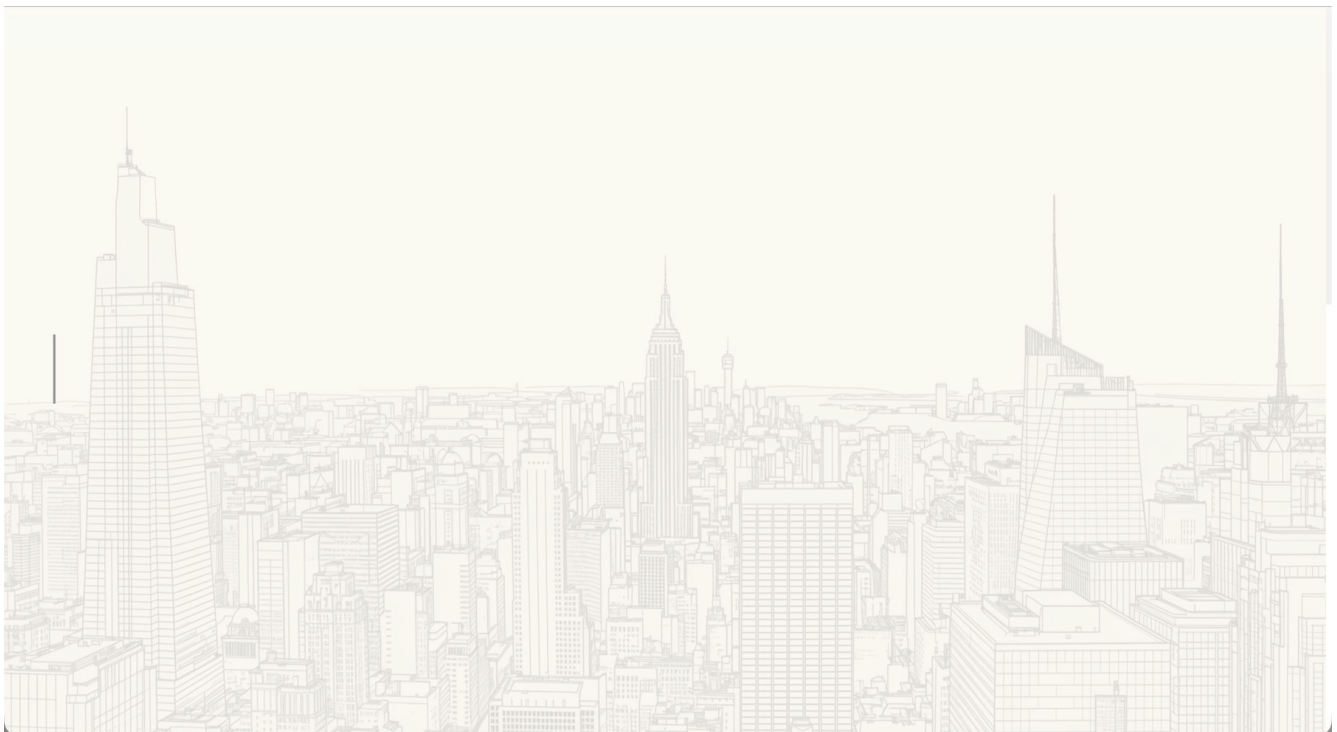
#	Verbatim Quote (abbreviated)	Source (Author, Title, Year, Page)
63	"The Lincoln Building, erected at 1 Union Square in 1889, is an example adapted from Romanesque work."	 WPA, <i>WPA Guide to NYC</i> , 1939, p. 203 [page scan]
64	"the Lincoln Building (R. H. Robertson, 1890), 1-3 Union Square West."	 Stern, <i>New York 2000</i> , 2006, p. 377 [page scan]

100-102 East 17th Street — Tammany Hall: The Iconography of Legitimacy

#	Verbatim Quote (abbreviated)	Source (Author, Title, Year, Page)
65	"On the southeast corner of East 17th Street and Union Square East, at 100-102 East 17th Street, stands the second of the district's institutional buildings. Tammany..."	 Dolkart, <i>Gramercy</i> , 1996, p. 78 [page scan]
66	"a dignified architectural treatment, one of the chief motifs of which are the severe Colonial columns in the centers of the Union Square and the Seventeenth-street..."	 Dolkart, <i>Gramercy</i> , 1996, p. 78 [page scan]
67	"The Colonial Revival was undoubtedly chosen not only because it was reminiscent of the architecture of the early republic, but also because it symbolized the government..."	 Dolkart, <i>Gramercy</i> , 1996, p. 78 [page scan]
68	"The Society of Tammany was attempting to associate itself with the ideals of early American democracy."	 Dolkart, <i>Gramercy</i> , 1996, p. 78 [page scan]
69	"This distinguished neo-Georgian facade, with its rusticated stone base, double-height pilasters, and sculptural reliefs in terra cotta and limestone, was inspired by the..."	 Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 679 [page scan]
70	"Tammany Hall, now a byword for municipal corruption, once dominated the City's political arena"	 Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 679 [page scan]

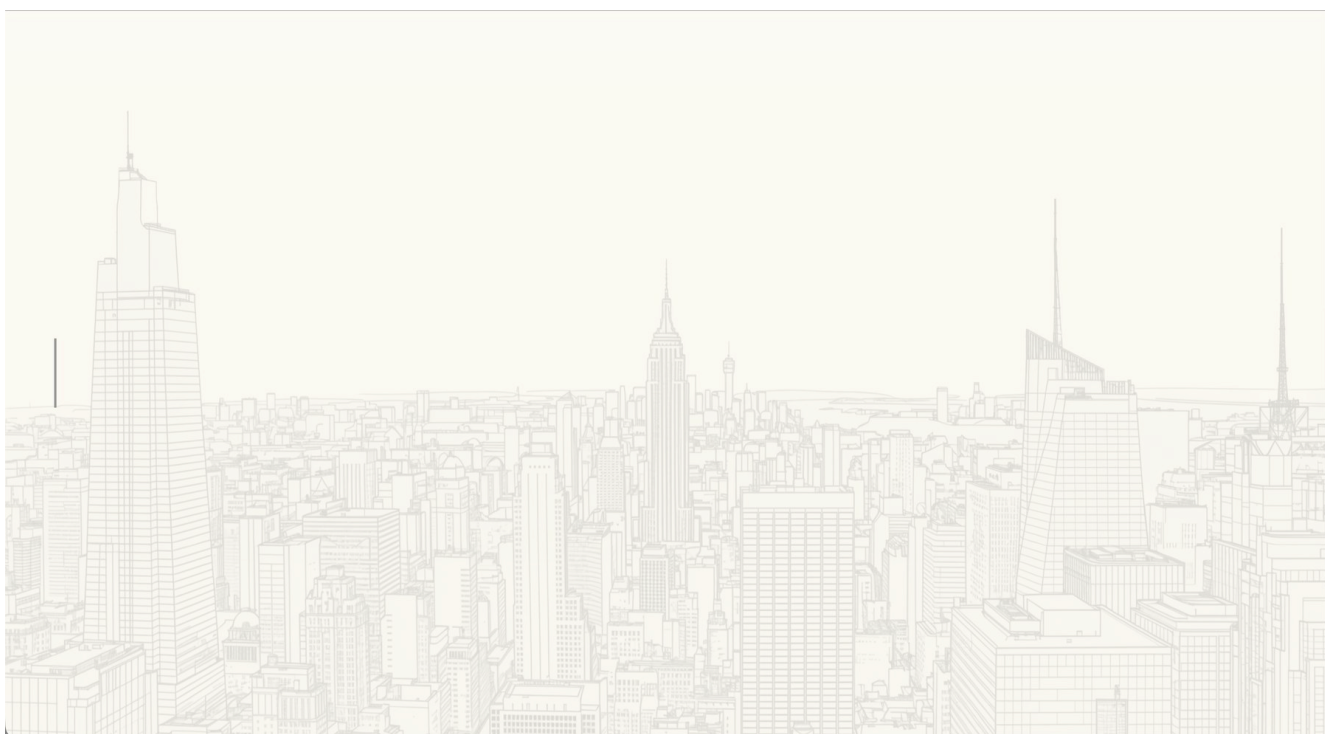
Coda: The Square as Architectural Palimpsest

#	Verbatim Quote (abbreviated)	Source (Author, Title, Year, Page)
71	"The diverse architecture of the buildings surrounding Union Square does not supply the unified feeling of enclosure implied by the word "square," but it does offer an..."	WPA, <i>WPA Guide to NYC</i> , 1939, p. 203 [page scan]
72	"Three divisions of each facade are clearly marked: a base ornamented with classical details, an intermediate portion of undecorated masonry pierced by regular windows..."	WPA, <i>WPA Guide to NYC</i> , 1939, p. 203 [page scan]
73	"like the Noah's Ark of New York, rescuing at least two of every kind from the curling seas of concrete."	St Louis, <i>Lonely Planet New York City</i> , 2016, p. 163 [page scan]
74	"The trick to any stroll through this zone is to look up. Each building brings an animated story to the streetscape, and many have been lovingly restored and given..."	Kahn, <i>City Secrets New York City</i> , 2002, p. 189 [page scan]



SOURCE PAGES

28 scanned pages, one per cited source page. Each lists the highlighted quotes drawn from it.



Chase, *New York The Wonder City*, 1932, p. 198

Quotes drawn from this page: 1 28



UNION SQUARE DISTRICT

Bounded on the south by 14th St. and on the north by 17th, between Broadway and 4th Ave. Laid out as a park in 1832.



and penny arcades. The Communists of New York make their headquarters at Union Square also.

Since the above picture was taken, the beautiful park in the center of the square is undergoing a great change. Due to excavations for subways, all the big shade trees were removed, grassy lawns and winding paths demolished, and the park generally wrecked. A stone wall of some 30 inches high has now been built around the entire area—broken only at intervals for entrances. This immense plot has been filled in with rich loam and when completed with new trees planted, new sod installed, winding pathways restored, and statues reset, Union Square will be even more inviting, and attractive than ever.

Union Square was originally a sand hill. Had it not been for the sand, Irving Place & Lexington Ave. would likely be part of Broadway today!

845.1

Union Square some years ago, was what New York's Great White Way is today. It was the amusement center of the city. Keith introduced vaudeville to New York in Union Square; Barnum's Museum was located in Union Square; The Academy of Music was on the N. E. Cor. of 14th St. & Irving Place—just a short block east of Union Square, and old Tammany Hall was just next door to the Academy. Today, Union Square is devoted to business, although East 14th St. has become quite a center for movie houses, vaudeville, dance halls,



**"853 BROADWAY"
BLDG.**

S. W. Cor. 14th St.
Faces Union Square

Ass'd Val. \$1,300,000



EVERETT BLDG.

45 Union Square
N. W. Cor. 16th St. & 4th
Ave.

Cost \$2,500,000
252 ft. high 18 Floors



**GUARDIAN LIFE
BLDG.**

50 Union Square
N. E. Cor. 17th St. & 4th
Ave.

Cost \$2,163,000
280 ft. high 22 Floors
Rent Area 125,000 sq. ft.

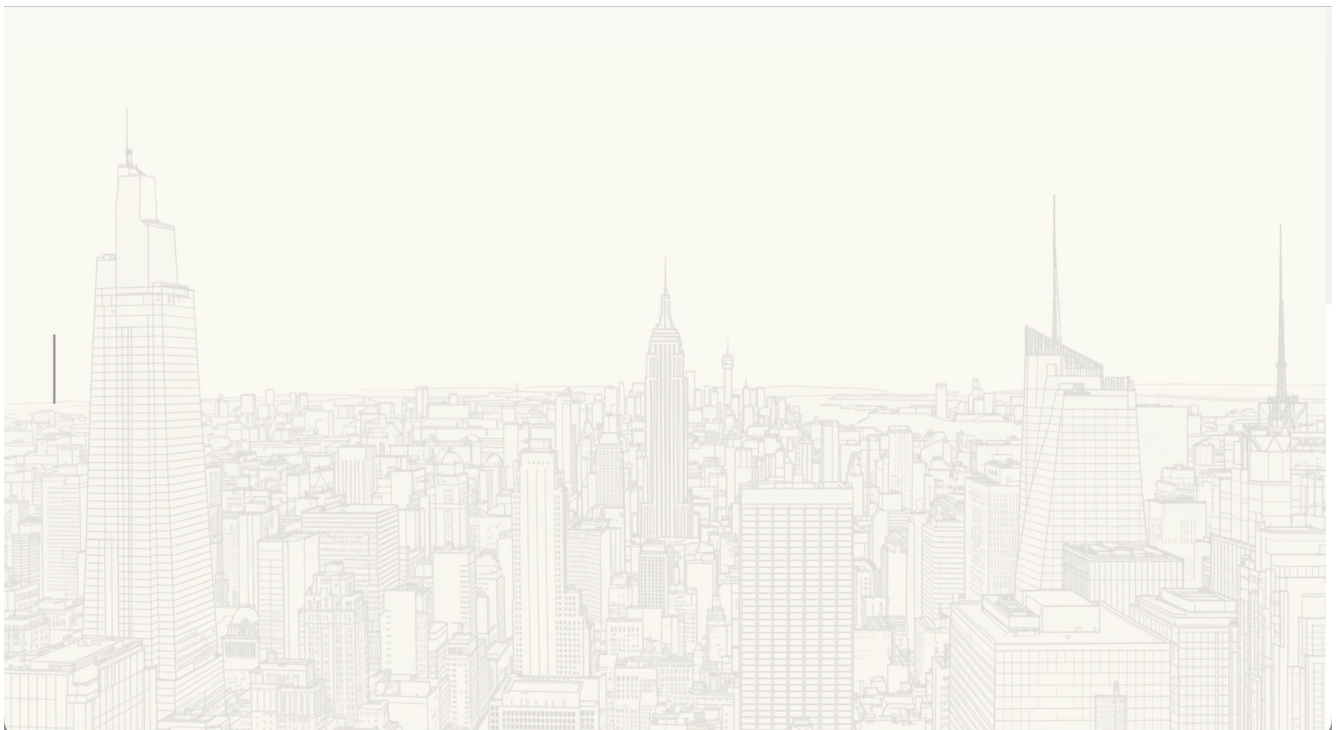
235 ft. high.....	21 Floors
Rent Area.....	68,600 sq. ft.
Housing.....	750
Completed	1928
Arch.....	Emery Roth
Bldr...G. Richardson Davis	Co.

Rent Area....	195,000 sq. ft.
Housing	2,300
Completed	1909
Owner..	Everett Investing Co.
Arch.,	Starrett & Van Vleck
Bldr....	Geo. A. Fuller Co.
Agent.....	H. Van R. Forest

Housing	1,600
Completed	1911
Owner..	Guardian Life Ins. Co.
Arch.....	D'Oench & Yost
Bldr.....	C. T. Wills & Co.
Manager.....	H. J. Smith

Bergman, *The Spiritual Traveler New York City*, 2001, p. 133

Quotes drawn from this page: 2



Ecuadorians was granted the right to bring a copy of the Madonna of Quinche from their homeland. The Lady, a small statue of the Madonna and Child, is installed in an exquisite gilded shrine, and Ecuadorian women regularly change the beautiful and elaborate dresses they have sewn for her. Each week planes from Ecuador bring fresh long-stemmed roses to adorn the sanctuary.

Today St. Ann's offers masses in English, Armenian, Spanish, and, by special dispensation, traditional Latin.

AROUND THE CORNER

➡ **Immaculate Conception Roman Catholic Church** (LM, 406–412 East 14th St., between First and Ave. A. 1896, Barney & Chapman. ☎ 254-0200) was built by Grace Church (see p. 130) as an Episcopalian chapel and social service center in what was then a poor immigrant neighborhood. Today we see only half of what this complex once was, but it still resembles a medieval urban church, looking after the spiritual, educational, and physical needs of its parish. The style of the buildings is late-Gothic or early-Renaissance French, featuring a bold tower on 14th Street, a church, and a small chapel. The buildings to the east of the tower were originally a hospital and community center, but are today clerical housing and offices. The central parking lot used to be a courtyard, and buildings on 13th Street included the rectory, a clubhouse, and the parish building with parlors and a reading room, Sunday school and cooking classes, and even a gym and swimming pool. The Roman Catholic Church bought this property in 1943. The belief in the Immaculate Conception—that Mary was born without sin—was proclaimed Roman Catholic dogma in 1854.

UNION SQUARE 845



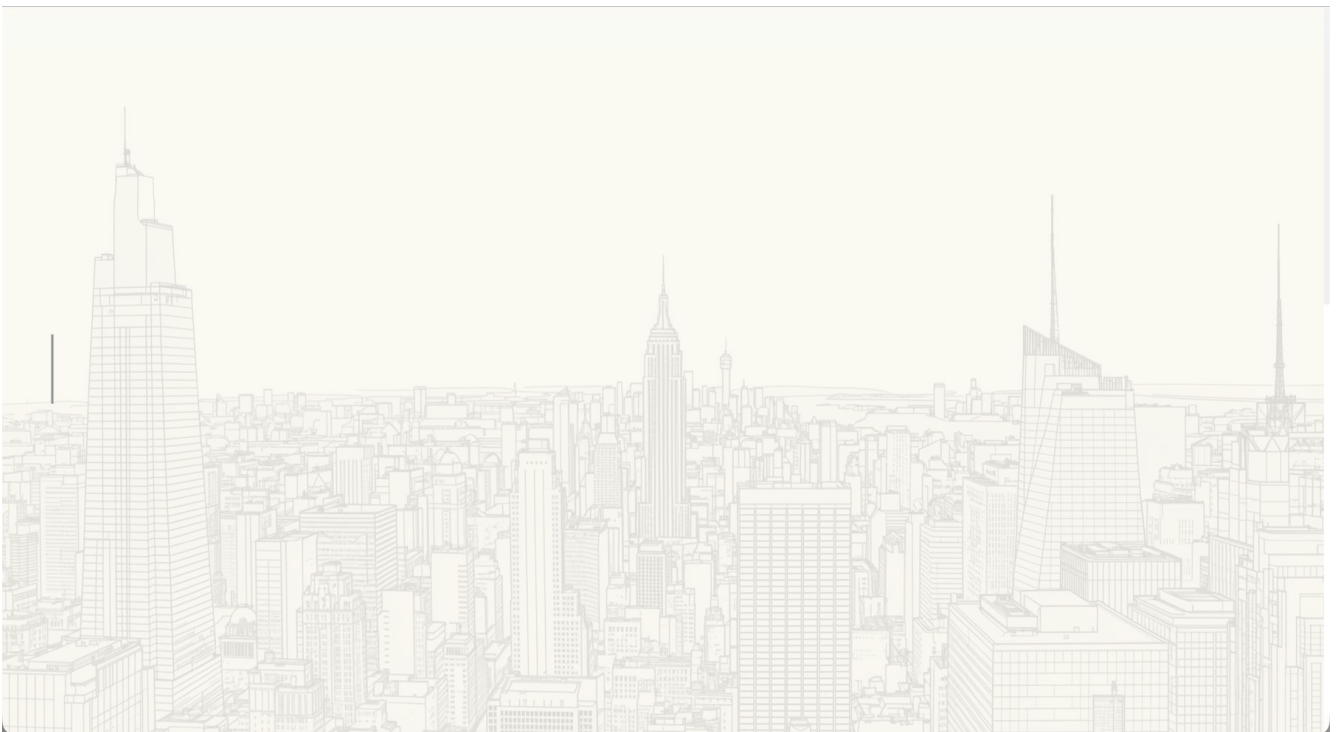
14th to 17th Sts., between Fourth Ave. and Broadway.

Union Square took its name from the fact that it was the spot where the Bowery and Bloomingdale Road (today's Broadway) came together, that is, united. The park opened in 1831, and it was soon surrounded by elegant mansions, theaters, and concert halls. From the Civil War until well into the twentieth century, workers' rallies and political protests were

often held here. The area went through a period of decline after World War II, but in the 1990s it sprang to life once again. The equestrian statue on the south side of the Square shows George Washington reclaiming New York from the British on November 25, 1783, and it stands just a few feet from where the event actually happened (Henry Kirke Brown, 1856). Other statues in the Square include one of Abraham Lincoln (Brown,

Holmes, *100 New Yorker*, 2004, p. 168

Quotes drawn from this page: 3



Union Square

From 14th to 17th Streets and from Union Square West (Broadway) to Union Square East (Park Avenue South)

Rivera and Kahlo passed much of their New York visit in the Union Square area—traditionally a site of social activism and political protest. In the 1930s, Union Square was rich soil for labor unions and socialist organizations. The New Workers School, where Rivera painted his series *Portrait of America*, was located at 51 West 14th Street, a few blocks west of Union Square; it is now a retail space that fails to evoke much feeling for the past. Rivera and Kahlo also lived and worked earlier in their visit at 8 West 13th Street, now part of the Parsons School of Design/New School complex.

The square marks the union of Fourth Avenue and Broadway and was saved from further development by the city in 1811. Soon after the park's creation, it became the natural and automatic gathering point for many rallies, protests, and marches in support of workers' rights. A quarter of a million people filled the neighborhood for a pro-Union Army rally in 1861; in 1882, ten thousand workers marched through Union Square to support the proposal for a national Labor Day. In 1908, an unsanctioned rally for the unemployed was quashed by hundreds of police. When two anarchists were killed by their own bomb, the police scattered the crowd (which was reportedly singing the "Marseillaise" defiantly) with clubs. Protesters against the conviction of Sacco and Vanzetti marched through in 1927. By the 1930s, when Rivera and Kahlo spent time in the area, Union Square had a solidly "red" reputation—many labor unions had opened offices around the park and rallies were held often. Shop owners tried to overshadow the park's reputation as a haven for socialists, anarchists, and leftist artists by draping the park in American flags. The history of social awareness and activism is remembered at the southwest corner of the park with a statue of Ghandi, pensive and in mid-stride.

El Museo del Barrio

1230 Fifth Avenue at 104th Street

tel. (212) 831-7272, www.elmuseo.org

El Museo hosted major exhibits of work by Rivera and Frida Kahlo in 2002. The museum's permanent collection is rich with pre-Colombian, traditional, and contemporary pieces from Puerto Rican, Caribbean, and Latin American artists.

Barbizon-Plaza Hotel

106 Central Park South at Sixth Avenue

1011

In 1933, Rivera and Kahlo stayed here. The Barbizon-Plaza Hotel had debuted just three years earlier as New York's "first fully equipped music-artist residence center." In New York, Kahlo filled her room with the prints of Mexican artist Jose Guadalupe Posada—

traditional folk art depictions of skeletons dancing, talking, playing—and sketched self-portraits on Barbizon-Plaza Hotel stationary. This building has since been converted to pricey condominiums.

.....

Museum of Modern Art (MoMA)

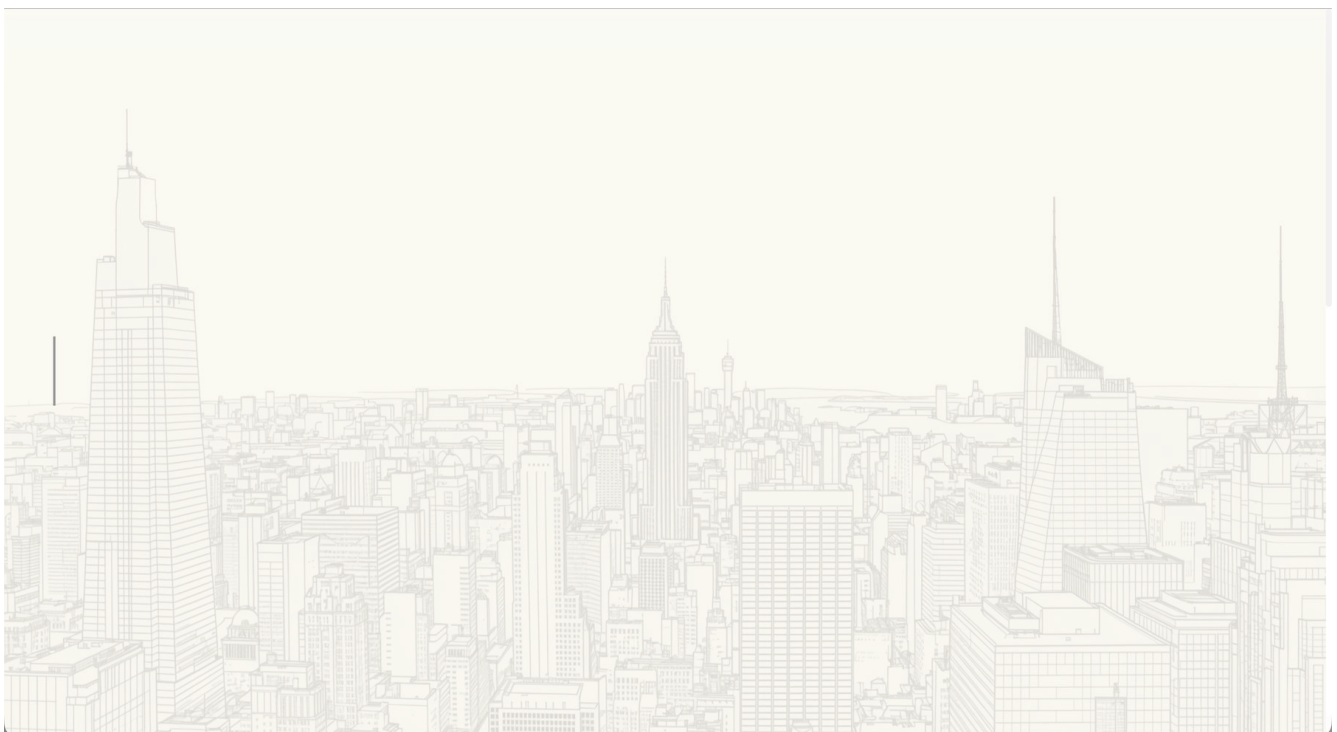
11 West 53rd Street, between Fifth and Sixth Avenues

tel. (212) 708-9400, www.moma.org

Included in the permanent collection of the museum are drawings by Rivera, including *Two Figures* (circa 1925). Frida Kahlo's *Self-Portrait with Cropped Hair* (1940) is also

Lockwood, *Manhattan Moves Uptown*, 1976, p. 167

Quotes drawn from this page: 4 5 6 7 8 9 10



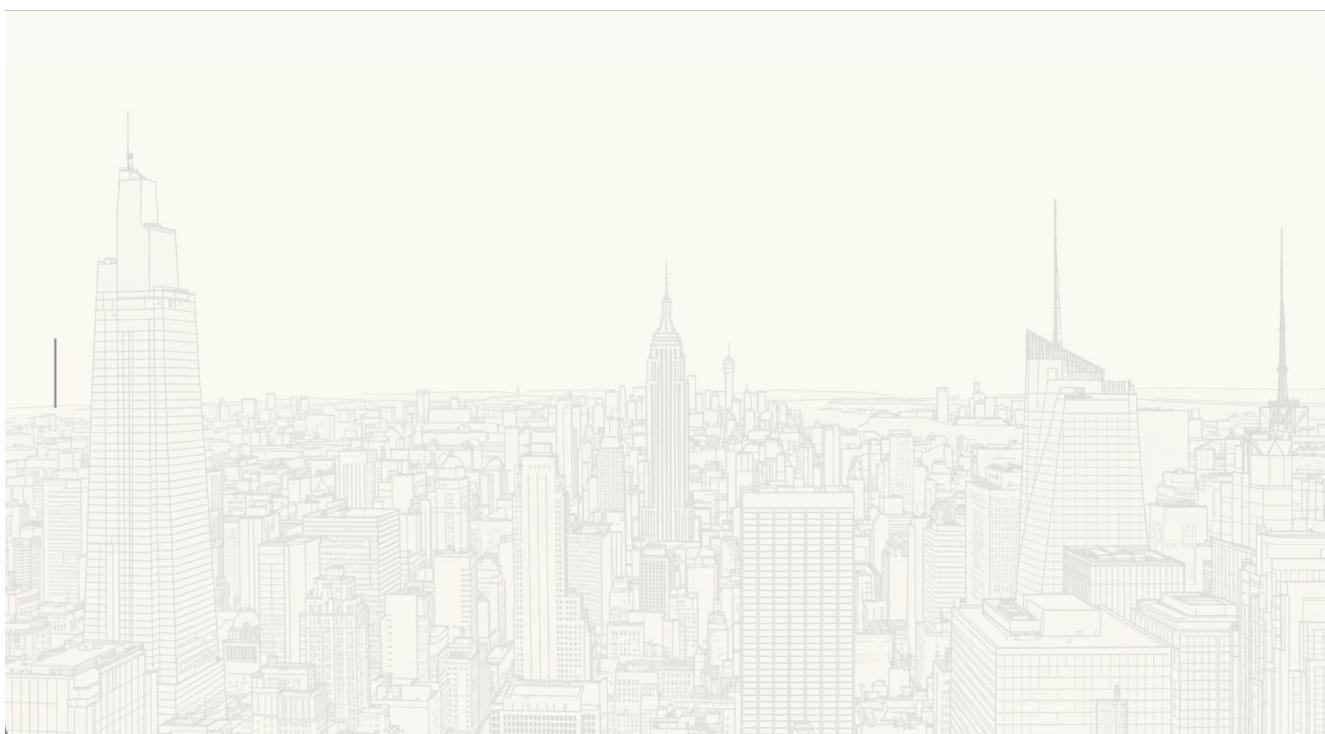
of new times, a new people, new tastes, and new habits."

The gateway to this uptown area was **Union Square**, a 845
three-and-one-half acre park, bounded by Broadway,
Fourteenth Street, Fourth Avenue, and Seventeenth Street.
The land was once part of Elias Brevoort's farm, but in 1762
he sold twenty acres lying west of the Bowery Road, or Third
Avenue, to John Smith, whose heirs subsequently sold it to
Henry Spingler for \$4750. In 1807 Broadway was regulated
from Astor Place to the vicinity of Twenty-third Street, and
in 1815 the city designated part of the land that became
Union Square as a public park. The city, however, did not
take title to Union Square or lay out the land as a park until
1831. A report by the Board of Assistant Aldermen declared:
"It is worthy of remark, that almost every stranger who visits
us, whether from our sister states or from Europe, speaks of
the paucity of our public squares; and that in proportion to
its size, New York contains a smaller number, and those few
of comparatively less extent than perhaps any other town of
importance." The report had recommended the immediate
acquisition of the property for Union Square because, "now
that the ground is unoccupied, the purchase can be effected,
which, in the lapse of a few years, when valuable buildings
are erected, will be impracticable, on account of the great
expense." Then "future generations" of New Yorkers would
lose the advantages of having a park, the most important one
being that parks serve as "ventilators to a densely populated
city."

With its enviable location at what was then the north-
ernmost limit of Broadway and just half a mile north of styl-
ish Bond Street, Union Square was assured of a fashionable
destiny, predicted the *Herald* as early as 1836. Just three years
later the *Mirror* reported: "Around Union Place new blocks
of houses, capacious and stately, are springing up with sur-
prising celerity . . . Fourteenth Street will doubtless be con-
sidered the heart rather than the extremity of the town in the
course of a few years." These fine row houses stood virtually
alone in fields, half a mile beyond the edge of the built-up
city, surrounded by shanties of the poor and run-down for-
mer country houses. A 150-year-old Dutch farmhouse still
stood on Fourteenth Street down by Second Avenue.

Lockwood, *Manhattan Moves Uptown*, 1976, p. 178

Quotes drawn from this page: 11 14 15 16



fourth streets, which were grander and of better scale for the highly ornamented brownstone-front houses than the usual 60-foot-wide streets. Although Fourteenth Street was at its most desirable in the blocks nearest Union Square and Fifth Avenue, it had, in the words of the *Herald*, fulfilled its destiny as "a noble thoroughfare . . . from river to river."

845

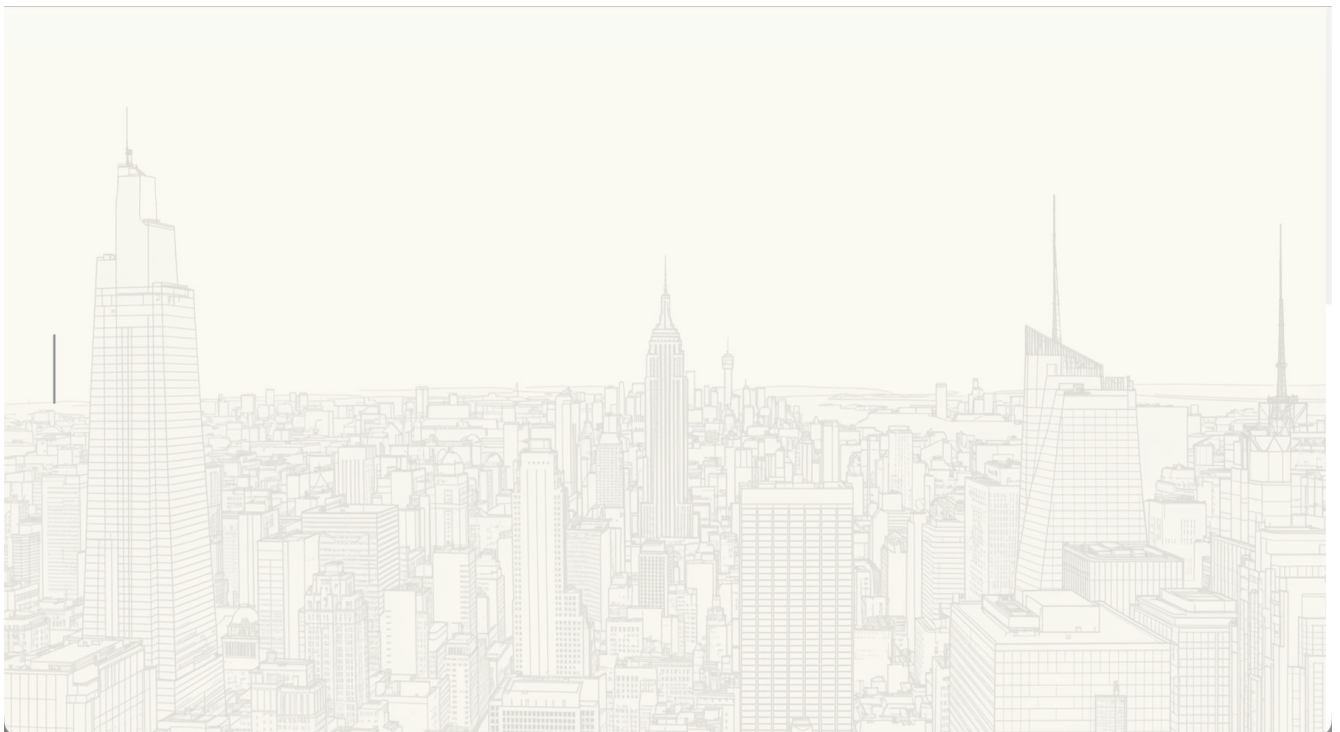
Once mansions and row houses began to blossom around Union Square in the mid-1840s, the park was planted with lawns, flower beds, trees, and shrubbery. Gas street lights were installed by 1849. Union Square was just the place to see some of the city's richest men strolling down the gravel paths, nursemaids pushing baby carriages, and young men and women courting. Even the birdhouses in the park reflected the nearby residents' concern for money, according to *Wood's Illustrated Handbook*. The "ingeniously contrived miniature buildings for these little birds, placed among the branches of the trees . . . represent different business departments as 'The Post Office,' 'The Custom House,' 'The Exchange,' etc., etc., etc., and it is very amusing to see the little creatures enter these different edifices, their busy, hurried air irresistibly giving the idea that they really know where they are going and have a purpose in it." As charming as these birdhouses may have seemed to some, old-moneyed New Yorkers, many of them still living below Fourteenth Street, remarked that the residents of Union Square and nearby Fifth Avenue were so immersed in daily business that even the neighborhood birds had to be busy at work all day long.

Broadway resumed its northward course at East Seventeenth Street, the upper edge of Union Square, but never enjoyed the vogue that it did south of Fourteenth Street. Comfortable red brick buildings, some private dwellings and others middle-class flats with shops on the ground floor, lined this stretch of Broadway, which now began its westward course and intersected Fifth Avenue at Twenty-third Street. The grandest building here was Peter Goelet's mansion, at the northeast corner of Nineteenth Street, which had peacocks strutting in its yard.

The other street leading north from Union Square was Fourth Avenue. New Yorkers had expected that Fourth

St Louis, *Lonely Planet New York City*, 2016, p. 163

Quotes drawn from this page: 12 26 27 73





TOP SIGHT UNION SQUARE 845.1

Union Square is like the Noah's Ark of New York, rescuing at least two of every kind from the curling seas of concrete. In fact, one would be hard-pressed to find a more eclectic cross-section of locals gathered in one public place. Amid the tapestry of stone steps and fenced-in foliage it's not uncommon to find denizens of every ilk: suited businessfolk gulping fresh air during their lunch breaks, dreadlocked loiterers tapping beats on their tabla, and skateboarders flipping tricks on the southeastern stairs.

Riches & Rags

Opened in 1831, Union Square quickly became the central gathering place for those who lived in the mansions nearby. Concert halls and artist societies further enhanced the cultured atmosphere, and high-end shopping quickly proliferated along Broadway, which was dubbed 'Ladies' Mile.'

When the Civil War broke out, the vast public space (large by New York standards, of course) was center stage for protesters of all sorts - from union workers to political activists. By the height of WWI, the area had fallen largely into disuse, allowing politically and socially driven organizations like the American Civil Liberties Union, the Communist and Socialist Parties, and the Ladies' Garment Workers Union to move in. Many decades later, the square remains a popular site for political and social protests.

For an unforgettable, sweeping view of Union Square and the Empire State Building beyond, hit DSW (p174), a 3rd-floor discount shoe store at the southern end of the square.

The Factory

After over a century of the continuous push-and-pull between dapper-dom and political protest, a third - artistic, if not thoroughly hippie-ish - ingredient was tossed into the mix when Andy Warhol moved his Factory to the 6th floor of the Decker Building at 33 Union Sq West. It was here, on 3 June, 1968, that disgruntled writer Valerie Solanas shot Warhol three times, seriously wounding him. The ground floor of the building is now occupied by a candy store chain - a telling sign of the times.

Metronome

565.2

A walk around Union Square will reveal a string of whimsical, temporary sculptures. Of the permanent offerings is an imposing equestrian statue of George Washington (one of the first public pieces of art in New York City) and a statue of peacemaker Mahatma Gandhi. Trumping both on the southeastern side of the square is a massive art installation that either earns confused stares or simply gets overlooked by passersby. A symbolic representation of the passage of time, *Metronome* has two parts - a digital clock with a

DON'T MISS

- ♦ Union Square Greenmarket
- ♦ *Metronome* art installation
- ♦ The view from DSW shoe store
- ♦ Eclectics, sit-ins and buskers

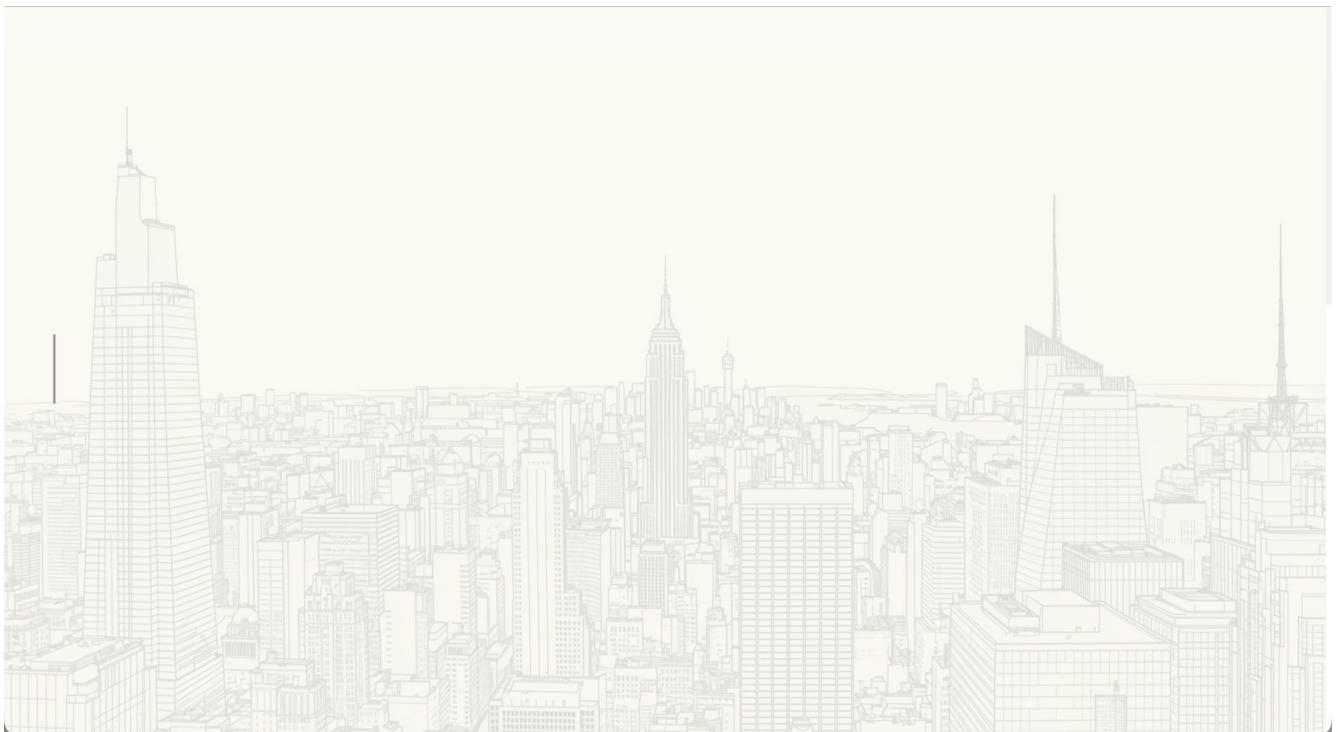
PRACTICALITIES

- ♦ Map p426
- ♦ www.unionsquarenyc.org
- ♦ 17th St, btwn Broadway & Park Ave S
- ♦ S 4/5/6, N/Q/R, L to 14th St-Union Sq

puzzling display of numbers, and a wand-like apparatus with smoke puffing out of concentric rings. We'll let you ponder the latter while we give you the skinny on what exactly the winking orange digits denote: the 14 numbers must be split into two groups of seven – the seven from the left tell the current time (hour, minute, second, tenth-of-a-second) and the seven from the right are meant to be read in reverse order; they represent the remaining amount of time in the day.

Lockwood, *Manhattan Moves Uptown*, 1976, p. 169

Quotes drawn from this page: 13



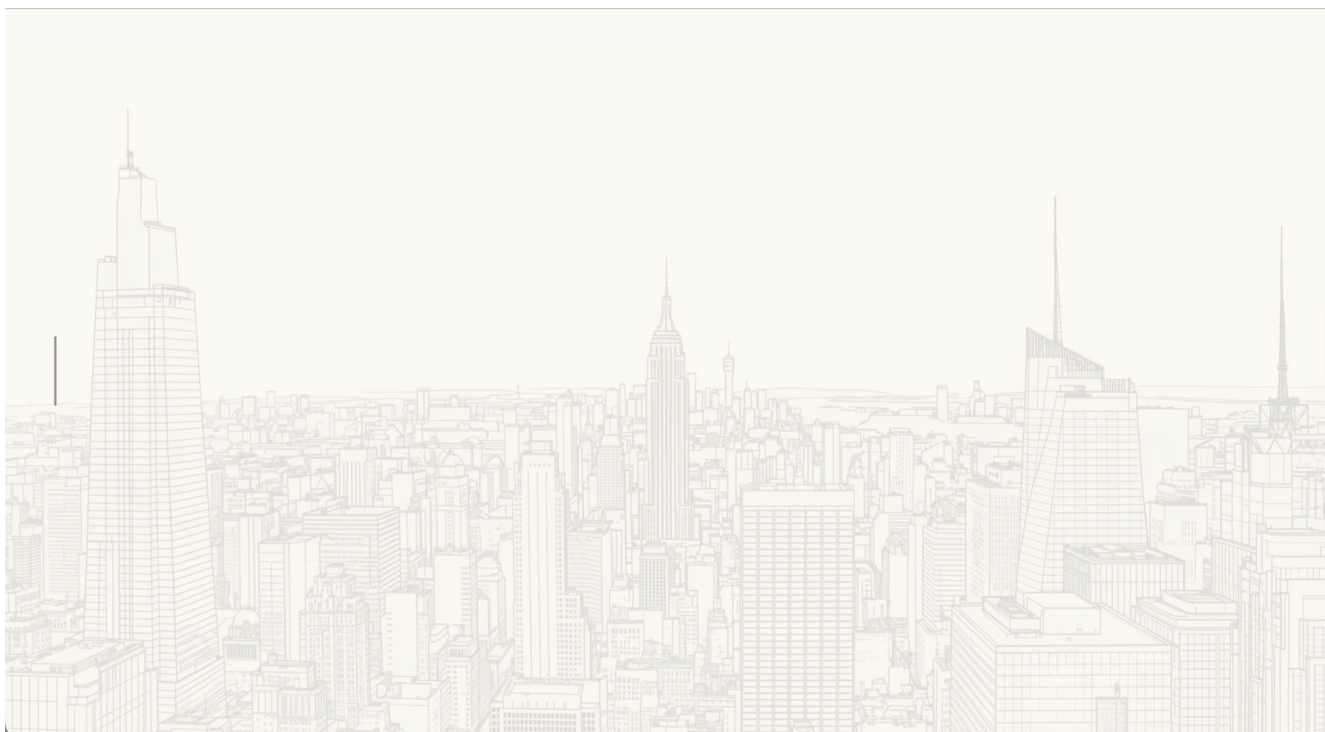
Union Square, ca. 1855

845



Lockwood, *Manhattan Moves Uptown*, 1976, p. 291

Quotes drawn from this page: 17 18 22 61



873.1

opened in 1851 at the southeast corner of Fourth Avenue and Eighteenth Street, a block from Union Square. That same year, the Eolian Hotel opened at 834 Broadway, the southeast corner of Thirteenth Street. The Everett House, completed in 1854, stood at 41 East Seventeenth Street, on the north side of the park. And the Academy of Music, built in the same year, stood just a few hundred feet from Union Square, at the northeast corner of Fourteenth Street and Irving Place.

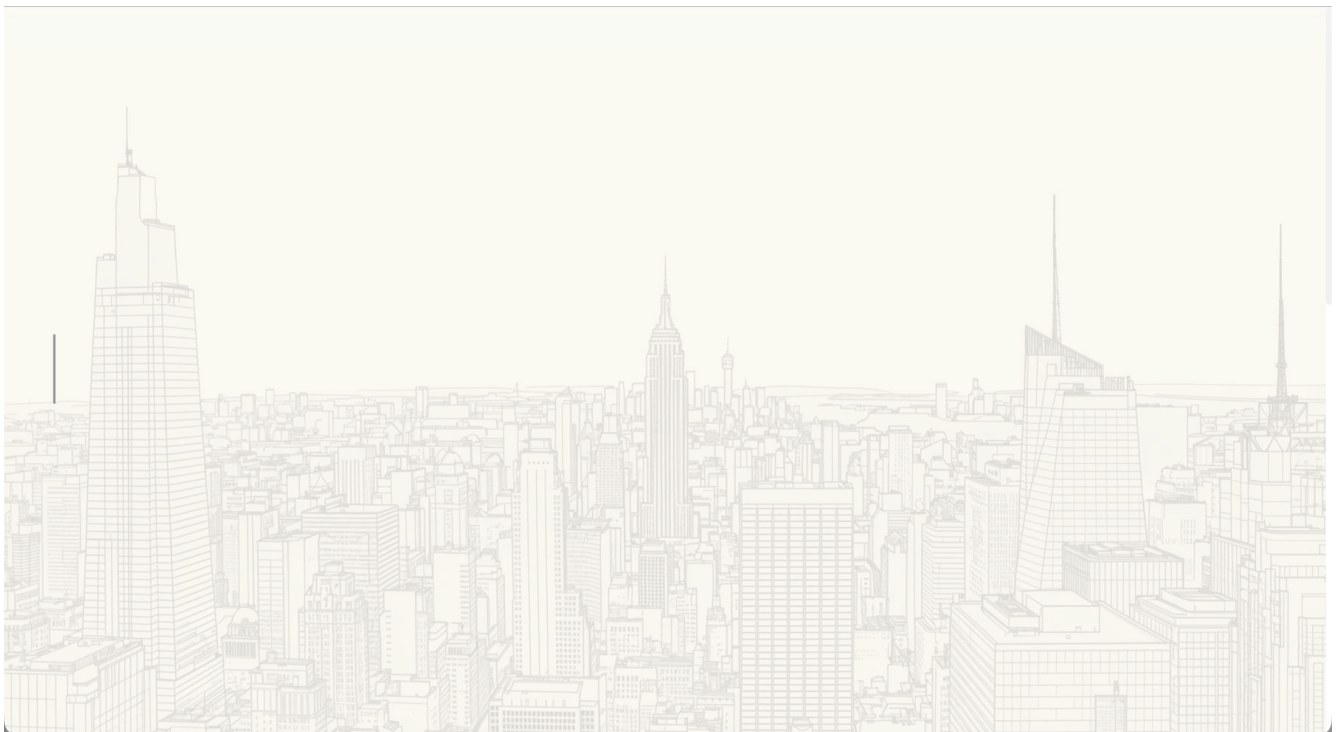
But boardinghouses and shops were another thing to the families living on Union Square, and if they weren't reason enough to move uptown, the rising values of houses in the area offered another incentive. By 1866 and 1867, houses on Union Square were selling for \$125,000 to \$180,000, up from

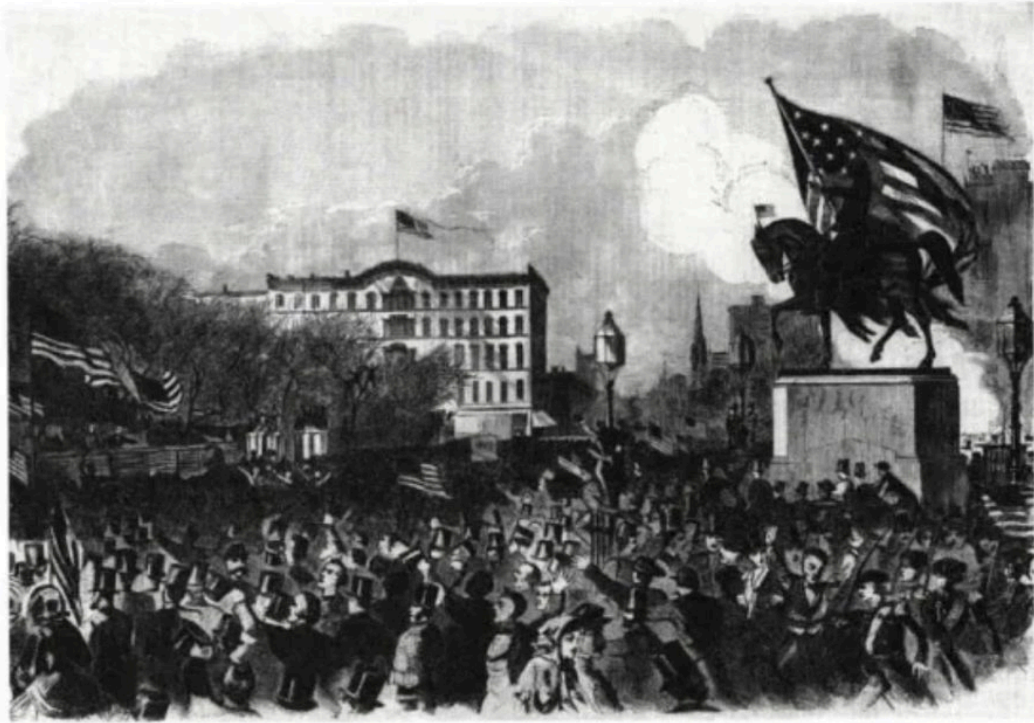
Bleecker Street, a slum
0



Leadon, *Broadway A History of New York in Thirteen Miles*, 2018, p. 118

Quotes drawn from this page: 19 20 21





The "Great Union Meeting" at Union Square, April 20, 1861.

845.1

ing the formerly tranquil square hummed with commercial activity, with once-grand mansions converted to boardinghouses, stores, and offices rented to chiropodists, coal dealers, dressmakers, milliners, hairdressers, furriers, and cloak manufacturers.

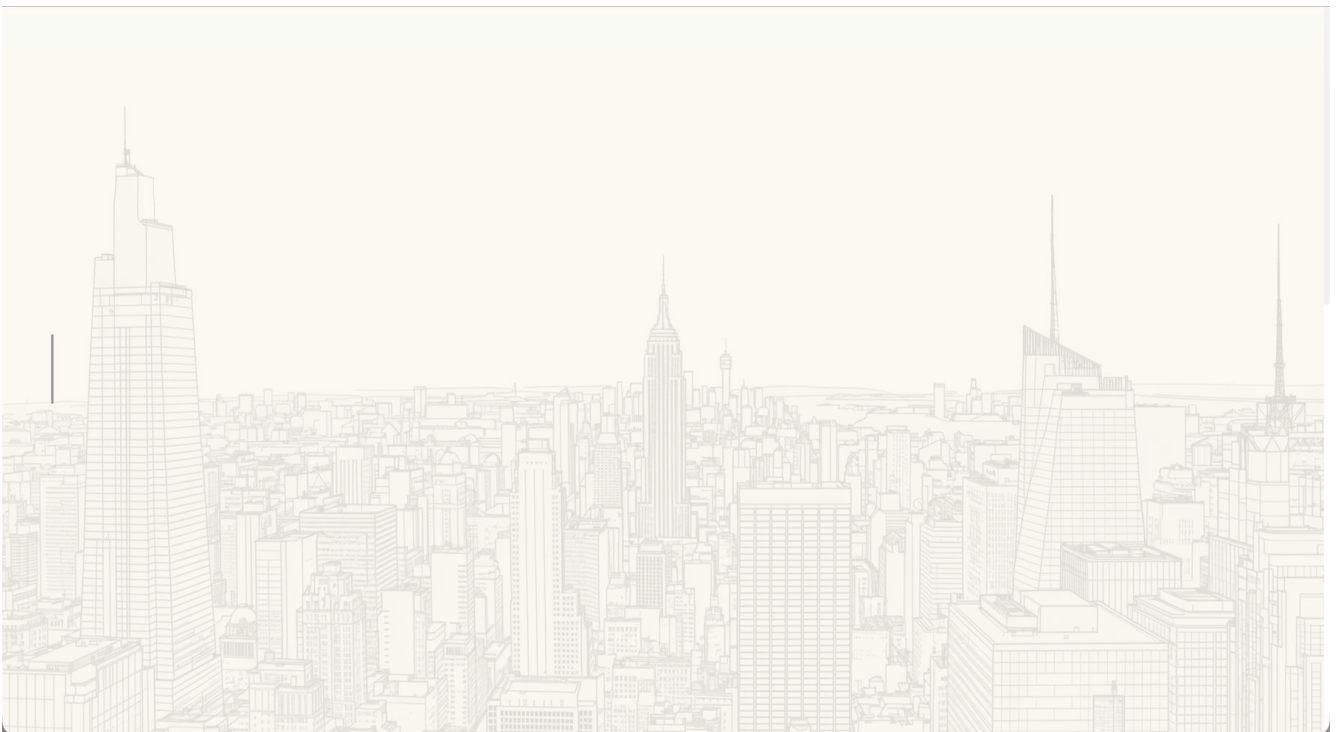
In 1872 the city hired Calvert Vaux and Frederick Law Olmsted, designers of Central Park, to remake Union Square according to a more up-to-date, picturesque aesthetic. Four years later, Olmsted was put in charge of the culminating pageant of the city's 1876 "Centennial Celebration," the most ambitious public demonstration Union Square had seen since the 1861 Great Union Meeting. Coming in the wake of several years of sectarian violence between the city's Catholics and Protestants, the Centennial Celebration was choreographed to depict New York as a thriving city at peace, where everyone, rich and poor, black and white, Protestant and Catholic, native-born and immigrant, got along famously.

immigrant, got along famously.

Just before midnight on July 3, following a torchlight parade up Broadway, its entire length decorated with flags and streamers and illuminated with gas jets, an estimated crowd of 40,000 to 50,000

Burrows & Wallace, *Gotham*, 1999, p. 869

Quotes drawn from this page: 23 24 25



young merchants, bankers, professional men, and clerks, left its Tompkins Market armory and marched down Broadway to the Jersey City ferry and off to defend the city of Washington, at that point virtually cut off and wide open to Confederate attack.

On Saturday the twentieth, what was reputedly the largest assemblage ever seen on the continent—somewhere between 100,000 and 250,000 people—flooded into Union Square. (In the war years, Union Square would replace City Hall Park as the center of civic life.) It was, all agreed, “a red, white and blue wonder.” Five stands swathed in the official colors groaned with speakers (including Major Robert Anderson, the hero of Sumter). The new bronze statue of Washington was wrapped in the flag that had been fired upon at Sumter. And Broadway emporiums from Stewart’s (at Reade) to Lord and Taylor’s (at Grand) were similarly bedecked as the city’s trade and benefit societies marched behind bands and flags of their own. Virtually every workshop in the city sent a delegation to the rally.

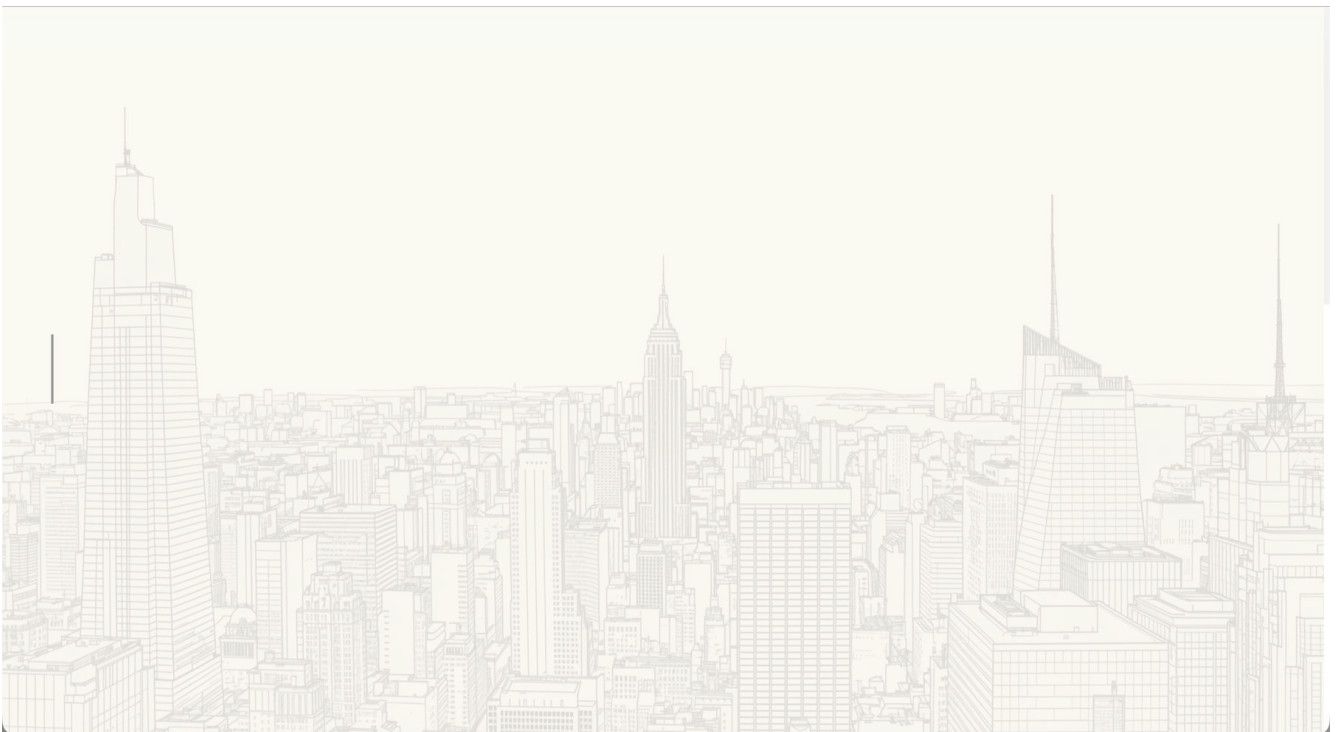
The meeting (as banker John Austin Stevens recalled) had been planned and orchestrated toward having the populace entrust “the guidance of their action” to “the merchants of the city, the chief representatives of its wealth and influence.” As expected, those assembled ratified establishment of a Union Defense Committee (UDC), composed of thirteen Democratic and twelve Republican businessmen. These gentlemen set about launching the war effort.

On Sunday, April 21, Lincoln, impressed by the *New Yorkers’* dispatch, surreptitiously ordered the transfer of two million federal dollars into UDC hands, with which to unofficially purchase arms, steamships, and supplies and to use in enlisting and dispatching troops to open the road to Washington. At the urging of none other than



Unknown Author, *New York Illustrated*, 1876, p. 63

Quotes drawn from this page: 29 30 31



DECKER BROTHERS' PIANO-FORTE WAREROOMS, 88 UNION SQUARE.



block 844

In the building represented by the above cut are the elegant and spacious ware and sales rooms of Decker Brothers, the justly-celebrated and well-known piano-forte makers of this city. The building can probably be best described by quoting from APPLETONS' JOURNAL, issue of April 23, 1870. The editor, in his "Table-Talk," after describing several new and beautiful buildings recently erected, concludes as follows:

"But, of all our new buildings, the handsomest is the one on Union Square, for Decker Brothers' piano ware-rooms. This building, though not large, is in a new direction in street-architecture, and we may well hope to see its example followed. It is of Ohio freestone and brick, in the style known as the ornamental Gothic, and, with the contrasts of tints in the material and its quaint windows, makes a most picturesque effect. One is so weary of brownstone, sandstone, white marble, and painted iron, in our architecture, that a front like this, so full of light and shadow, so mellow and rich in tone, so fresh and pleasing in design, is a very agreeable revelation. What a superb quarter of the city Union Square would be, if fronted with buildings as inspiring as this!"

The foundation of the house was unostentatiously laid in 1862, with a small capital in money, but a capital large in experience in all that was necessary to produce instruments to sell to a critical public—experience gained by an acquaintance from their earliest youth with every (even the minutest) detail of the mechanism of the piano-forte, and by having filled the most responsible positions in the establishments of the earlier manufacturers of our time. They indulged in no rosy fancies of sudden popularity and a quickly-realized fortune. Of simple tastes, they undertook the business not so much as a means to wealth as for the purpose of improving the manufacture. Being practical artisans themselves, and familiar with the capabilities of every man employed in the business in New York, they found no difficulty in securing the services of the highest skill for each department. Good mechanics prefer employment where their ability is not only well paid for, but is also properly appreciated, and the estimation in which the Decker Brothers were held was such as to cause the leading journeymen in other factories to seek engagements at their hands.

The instruments manufactured by this firm fully realize the standard of what a well-made piano, for tone and durability, should be. The firm is one of the most prominent of representative piano-forte makers in the world, having won this proud position by the intrinsic merits of the instruments of its make. The location of the building is convenient and on the most prominent thoroughfare in the city. The rooms are in all respects suited to the business, and afford every opportunity for testing the tone and for the inspection of the finish of their pianos. Every attention is shown to visitors, and altogether it is one of the most inviting and comfortable places in the city to visit.

Museyon Inc., *Art+NYC*, 2011, p. 208

Quotes drawn from this page: 32



MIDTOWN SOUTH

⑧ **WARHOL APARTMENT**

242 Lexington Avenue

In 1953, Andy Warhol and his mother moved to a modest two-story apartment above a dive bar called Florence's Pin-Up, where he lived until 1960.

⑨ **THE WHITE FACTORY**

33 Union Square West

In 1968 Warhol moved downtown to the Decker Building, where he set up his White Factory. A stark contrast to the anything-goes vibe of the Silver Factory, Warhol's Union Square studio was set up like an office. It was here that he was shot by Valerie Solanas in July 1968.

⑩ **ANDY WARHOL STUDIO**

860 Broadway

In 1974, Warhol moves to a nearby studio that came to be known as "the office." He stayed here until 1984.

⑪ **ANDY WARHOL'S FINAL FACTORY**

22 East 33rd Street

In 1984 Andy Warhol move the Factory and the offices of *Interview* to a converted Consolidated Edison building, where they remained until his death in 1987. The building no

HOTELS

⑫ **ACE HOTEL**

20 West 29th Street

212-679-2222

acehotel.com

This pet-friendly hotel — with a vintage-grunge look in the common areas complete with a street art-inspired sticker mural — is a good budget option near the Theater District. With a lively bar scene, the hotel is a hangout for both visitors and New Yorkers. DJs often play music in the lobby bar.

⑬ **CARLTON ARMS HOTEL**

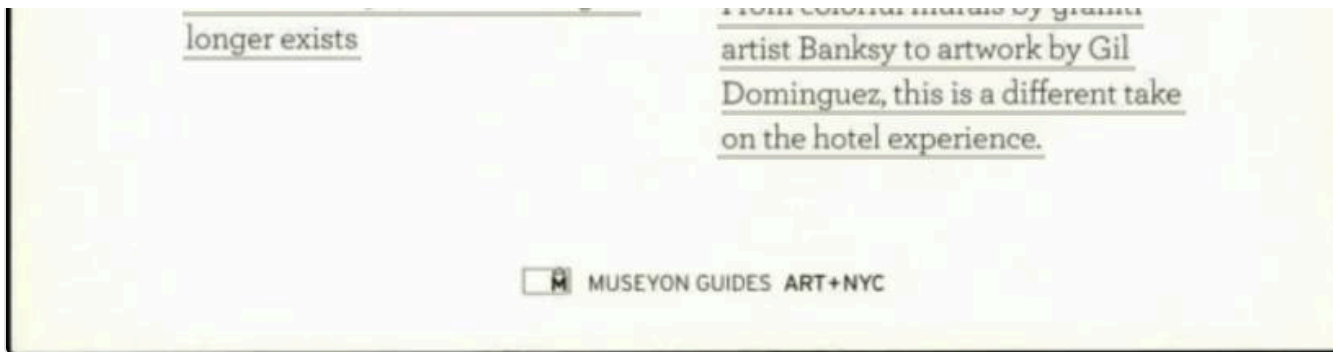
160 East 25th Street

New York, New York 10010

212-679-0680

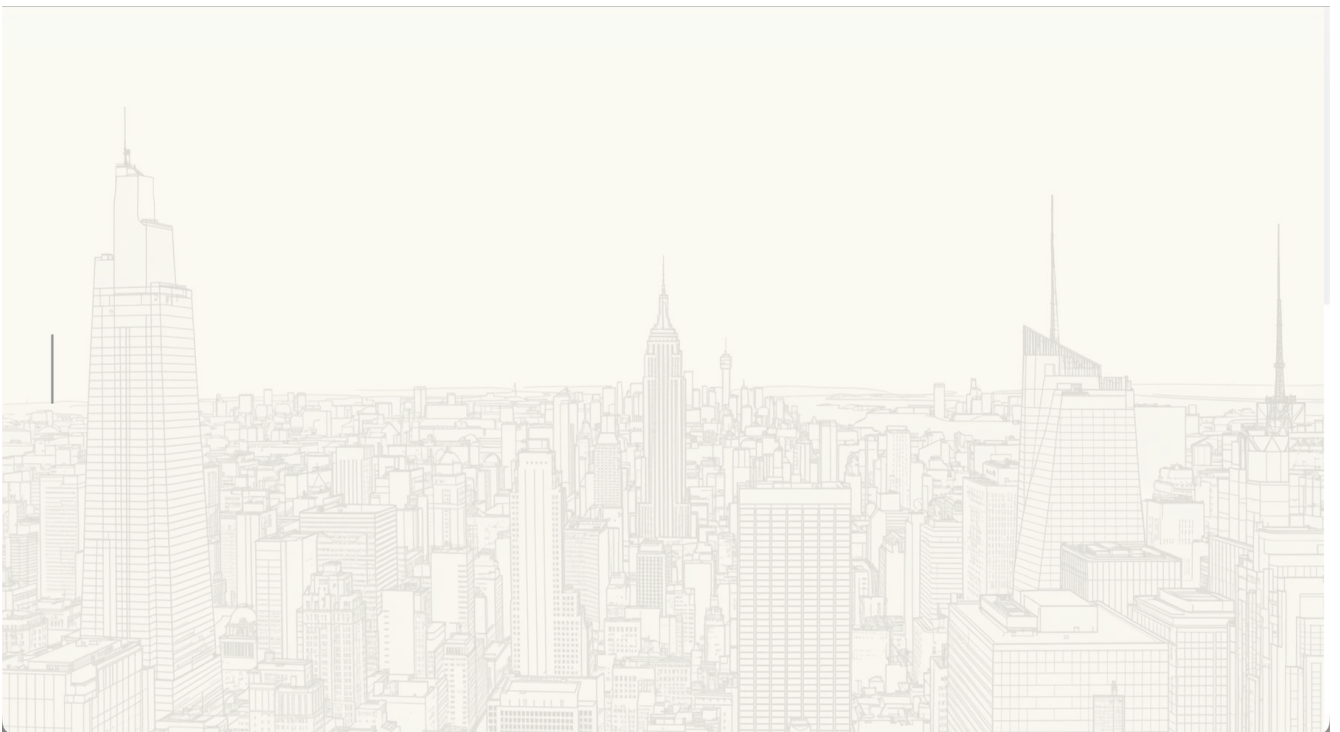
carltonarms.com

This quirky, budget-friendly hotel has a very storied history: from a modest shelter for visiting farmers and businessmen in the early 1900s, to a speak-easy and casino hangout during Prohibition, not to mention a haven for drug addicts, prostitutes and other unsavory characters from the '50s through the early '80s. Today, the hotel is a mecca for art enthusiasts. Artists come from all over the world to paint the walls of the guest-rooms, hallways and bathrooms. From colorful murals by graffiti



Alleman, *New York The Movie Lover's Guide*, 2005, p. 212

Quotes drawn from this page: 33



dio in 1913 for the Mutual Film Corporation, Biograph's status fell quickly, and in 1915 the company was dissolved. Many of its films survive, however, thanks both to Griffith, who saved copies of all his productions, and to the Museum of Modern Art, which acquired Griffith's collection in the mid-1930s for its then new film department.

342

In 1975, a plaque was dedicated by former Biograph beauties Lillian Gish and Blanche Sweet at the site of the historic town-house studio at 11 East 14th Street. The day after the ceremony, however, the plaque mysteriously disappeared, and there have been no further efforts to put up a new one. There should be. And while we're talking about plaques, there also ought to be one at Biograph's original studio site at 841 Broadway.

2. THE FACTORY SITE

33 Union Square West

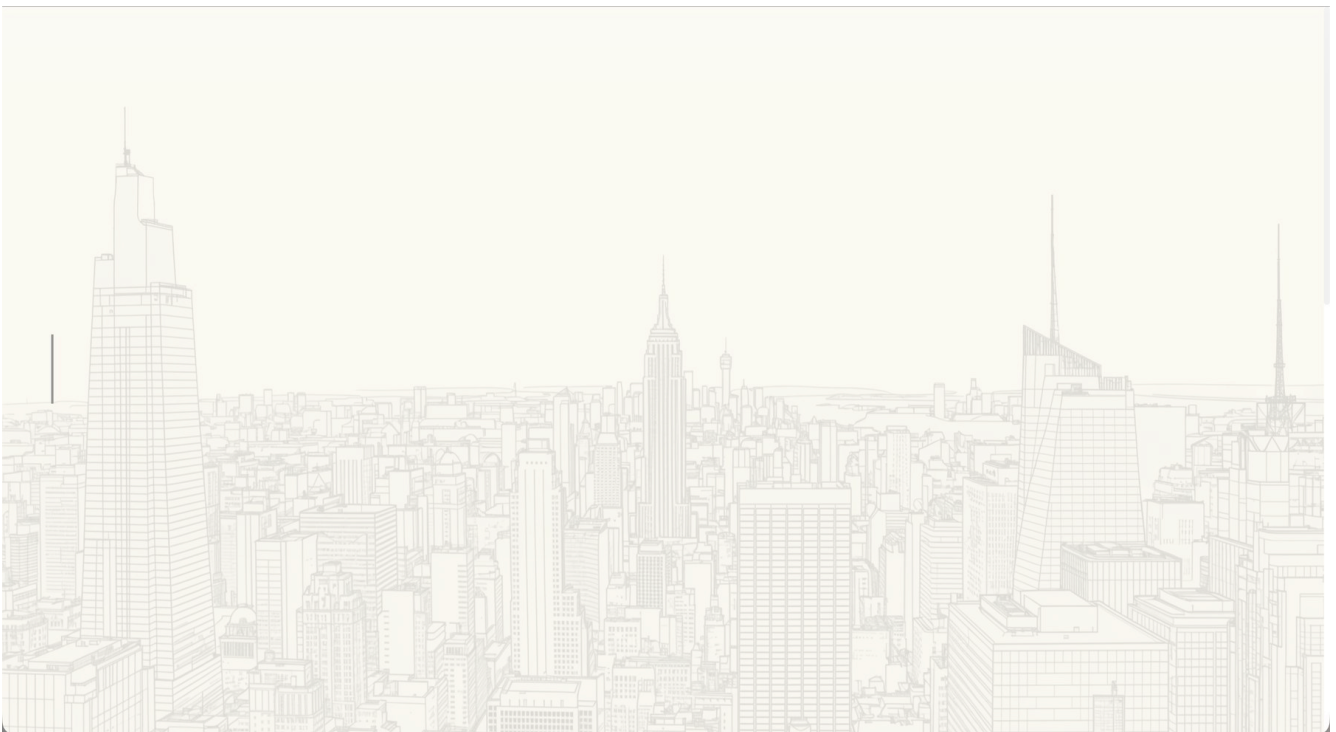
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It was the best of times, it was the worst of times . . . it was the 1960s. Underground avant-garde films were the rage—especially those created by a platinum-blond NYC artist named Andy Warhol. Andy made his films—which often used stationary cameras and ranged from quickies like *Blow Job* to six-hour epics like *Sleep*—at a series of New York City studios he called “factories.” Andy's first factory, which he occupied between 1963 and 1967, was at 231 East 47th Street. With its walls covered in silver Mylar, the place hosted a constant stream of drop-ins from the street, many of whom wandered in and out of whatever film Warhol and his associates happened to be shooting at the time. Just like in the old days of Hollywood, this wacky, carefree moviemaking organization also boasted its own superstars. Among them were Viva, Ultra Violet, Baby Jane Holzer, Paul America, Joe Dallesandro, and Edie Sedgwick, whose tragic, brief, fast-lane life and subsequent death of a drug overdose were documented in both the 1982 best-selling book *Edie* and in the 1983 film *Ciao! Manhattan*.

In early 1968, Warhol and company moved from their 47th Street base (which was about to be demolished for an apartment building) to the sixth floor of a ca. 1900 loft building at 33 Union Square West. Although now the walls were painted white and everything was very crisp and minimal, the moviemaking at

Binkowski, *Musical New York*, 1999, p. 107

Quotes drawn from this page: 34



series of live recordings ("Live at the Village Vanguard" and others) have made this club legendary.

Max Gordon opened the club in 1934, and it served as a venue for poetry readings, jazz, swing, pop, folk, and cabaret over the years. Both the Thad Jones and Mel Lewis orchestras appeared here, as did Dizzy Gillespie, Mary Lou Williams, Coleman Hawkins, Thelonius Monk, Keith Jarrett, and Eddie Heywood, among many others.

Photographs on the walls chronicle the many performers who have delighted audiences at the Vanguard during its illustrious history.

SQUARES, PARKS, ENCLAVES AND NEIGHBORHOODS

■ UNION SQUARE

Only the ghosts of the famous Union Square musical sites remain. This was once the center of the musical world, and it is still an interesting area. A most famous nineteenth-century edifice was the Academy of Music, situated on the northeast corner of East 14th Street and Irving Place. Once an opera house for the old-line rich, it was forced out of business by the newer and more opulent Metropolitan Opera. Victor Herbert, longtime patron of Luchow's restaurant (110 East 14th Street), founded ASCAP here. Tony Pastor's Opera House (between Third Avenue and Irving Place) was where vaudeville supposedly originated, with such performers as Lillian Russell and George M. Cohan. The first Steinway Hall (107-109 East 14th) accommodated 2500 people and was once the site

870.2

559

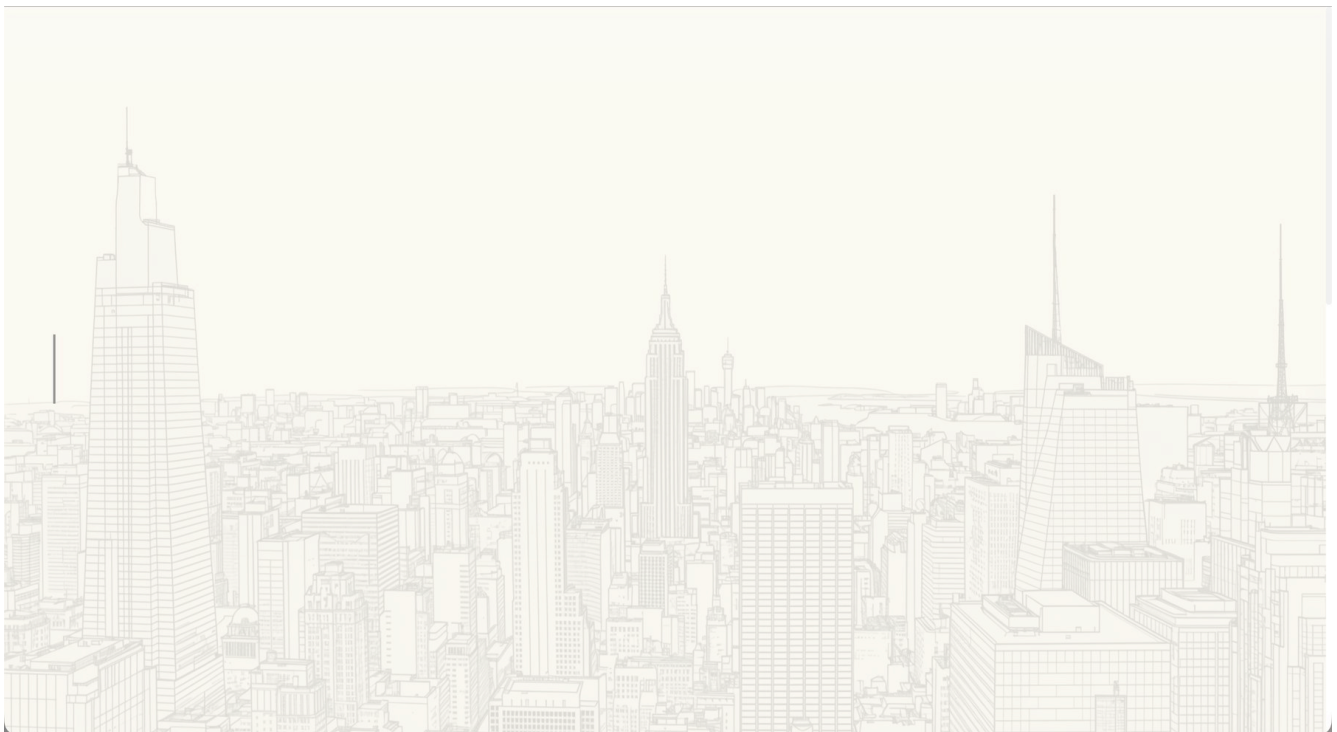
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105 East 14th) accommodated 2500 people and was once the site of New York Philharmonic concerts as well as numerous recitals by piano virtuosi. Nearby, Chickering Hall (northwest corner of Fifth Avenue and 18th Street) opened in direct competition to Steinway with an inaugural series performed by Hans von Bulow. All are gone. Only the Decker Piano Building remains (33 Union Square West). A beautiful architectural example of bygone times, its days as a piano firm are long gone, too.

820

WPA, *WPA Guide to NYC*, 1939, p. 203

Quotes drawn from this page: 38 63 71 72



trymen know what precious blessings they are in possession of and which no other people on earth enjoy."

The diverse architecture of the buildings surrounding Union Square does not supply the unified feeling of enclosure implied by the word "square," but it does offer an interesting record of architectural styles that have been popular in past years. The LINCOLN BUILDING, erected at 1 Union Square in 1889, is an example adapted from Romanesque work; at No. 33 the Union Building, built in 1893, has richly framed windows inspired by Spanish Moorish design. The cast-iron front widely popular in the last quarter of the nineteenth century is exemplified by the AMALGAMATED BANK BUILDING at 11-15 Union Square, erected in 1870-71.

Most of the recent buildings, however, are faced with stone. Three divisions of each façade are clearly marked: a base ornamented with classical details, an intermediate portion of undecorated masonry pierced by regular windows, and a crowning element at the top consisting of arched windows and an elaborate cornice. The BANK OF THE MANHATTAN COMPANY at 31 Union Square and the HARTFORD BUILDING at No. 41 are typical.

The decreased demand for industrial floor area and the increased number of vacancies, in the years following the financial crisis of 1929, led to the popularity of a new type of structure—the taxpayer. This was designed to yield rent that was sufficient to pay the real-estate taxes; it could be replaced by a larger building during a more prosperous period. Such an example is at 31 EAST SEVENTEENTH STREET, a two-story structure of light-cream brick and panels.

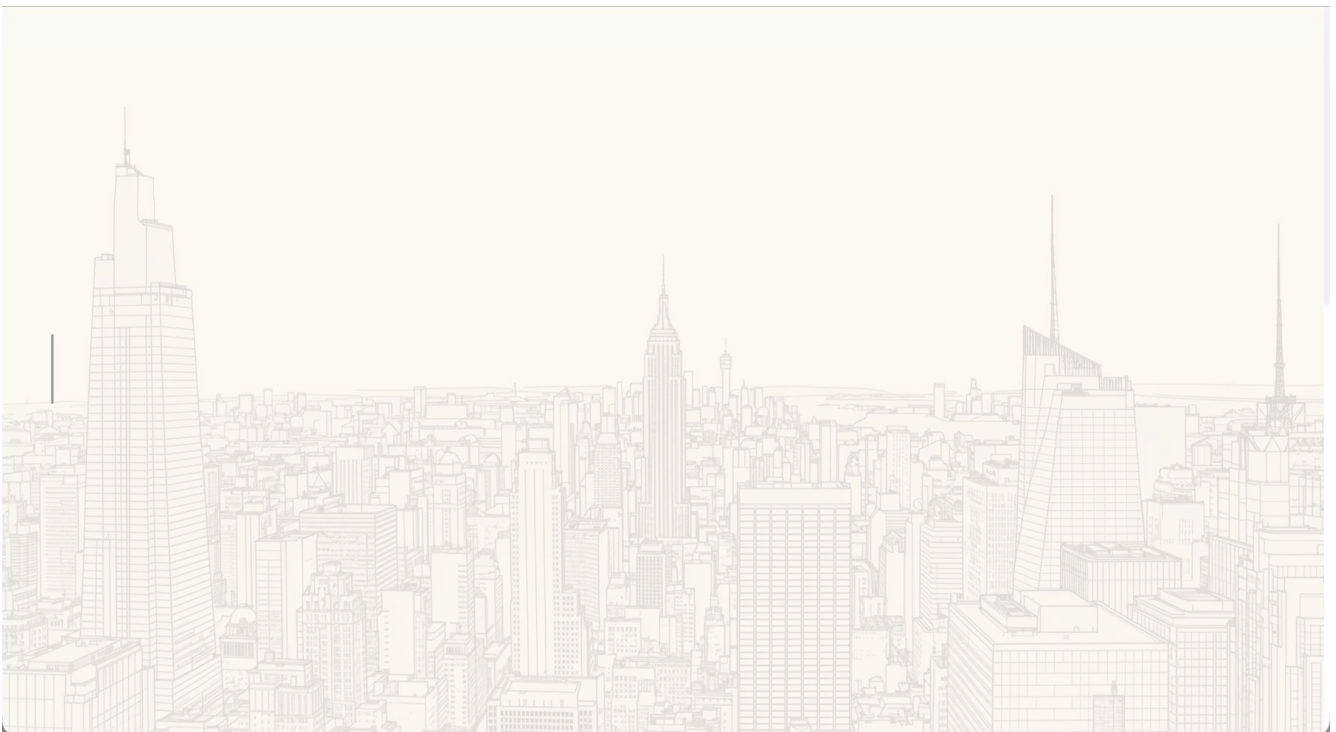
In the northeast corner of the square—Seventeenth Street and Fourth Avenue—is TAMMANY HALL, the headquarters of the city-wide system of Democratic political clubs. Here the inner council of sachems meets to set Tammany's policies and to plan campaigns. When the organization wins at the polls, club leaders and district workers swarm to the Hall for a rousing election night celebration, but such joyful gatherings have been infrequent in recent years. The building, erected in 1929, has some resemblance to the old Federal Hall that stood at Broad and Wall Streets.

Although the CONSOLIDATED EDISON BUILDING is one block east of the square—Fourteenth Street and Irving Place—it is already part of the square's tradition. The building, completed in sections between 1915 and 1929, occupies the site of the old Academy of Music. The mausoleum-like

tower rises 531 feet above the square; its bright lights, visible for miles, and the illuminated dial of the great clock below, are welcome landmarks.

Hennessy, *Walking Broadway*, 2020, p. 97

Quotes drawn from this page: 39 40



Plant forms are abstracted and stylized under the influence of Moorish decoration to create this lush patterning. The central tower is an Islamic extravaganza and was once topped by a minaret.

From 1967 to 1973 the sixth floor of the Decker Building housed Andy Warhol's celebrated Factory. It was here in 1968 that the artist was shot by Valerie Solanas. Warhol subsequently relocated the Factory diagonally across the street to 860 Broadway.



97

E Bank of the Metropolis

31 Union Square West

844

1903 · BRUCE PRICE

The familiar, sober classical vocabulary of bank architecture is enlivened here by a welcoming two-story bowed portico supported by a pair of gray granite Ionic columns facing Union Square. The long 16th Street elevation also features some distinctive touches. Notice the flattened arches floating in the openings of the ground level arcade and the lush foliate ornament in the panels under the windows higher up. A powerfully detailed balcony at the thirteenth story prepares the way for a bold copper cornice.

The block between 14th and 15th Streets offers two solid and accomplished historic structures: the **Spingler Building** (5 Union Square West, 1897, W. H. Hume and Sons) and the **Lincoln Building** (1 Union Square West, 1889, R. H. Robertson). The two facades share many compositional details, but one architect has chosen a classical vocabulary while the other has embraced the Romanesque.

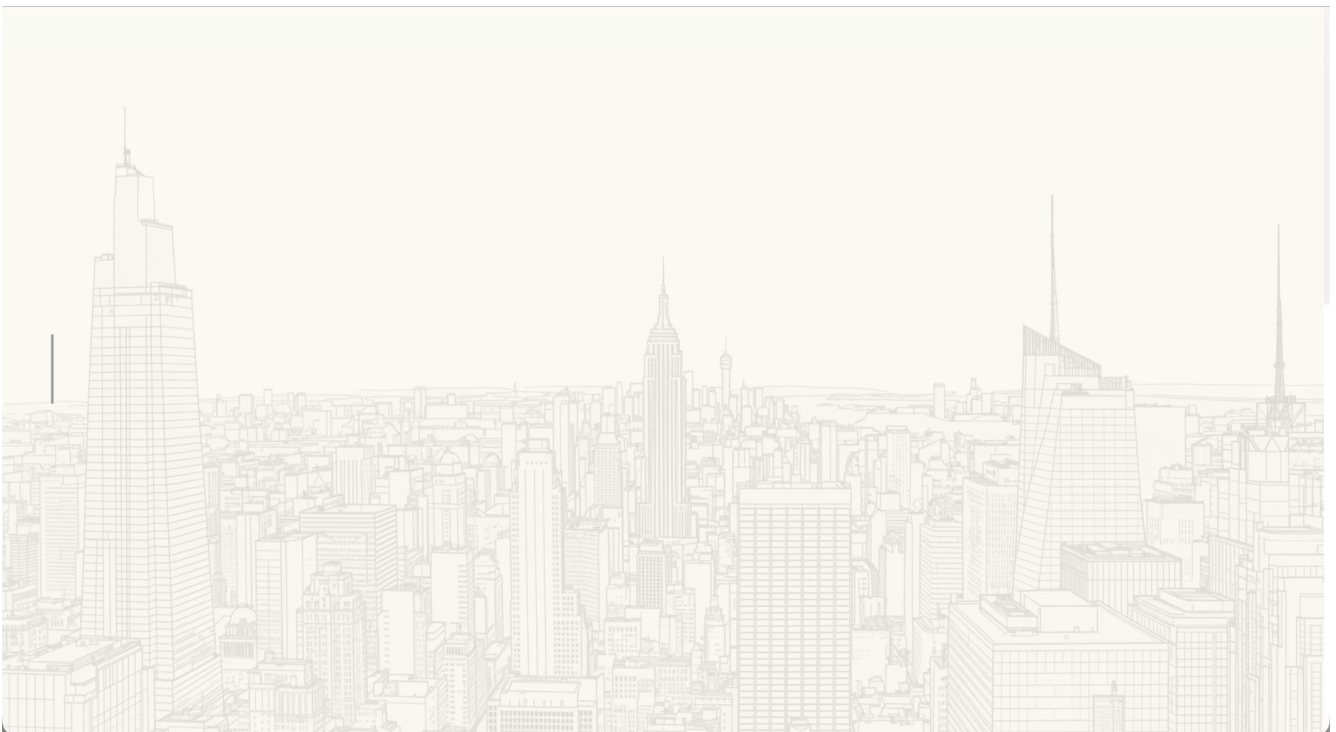
842

More unusual is the contemporary building at 15 Union Square West. Behind the steel and glass are the arches of the cast iron facade from John Kellum's 1869 headquarters for **Tiffany & Company**. The top seven floors were added to the original five when the building was converted to condominiums in 2009.

842

Postal & Dolkart, *Guide to New York City Landmarks*, 2009, p. 76

Quotes drawn from this page: 41 42



MANHATTAN

was designed to attract the attention of riders on the Sixth Avenue Elevated, which ran in front of the building.

195 **5, 7, 9, 17, 19, 21, and 23 West 16th Street** (c. 1845–46), designated individually 1990. In the 1840s the streets adjacent to Fifth Avenue just north of 14th Street were developed with row houses. Most of these structures were demolished as commerce invaded the area in the late 19th century, but West 16th Street retains a significant number of Greek Revival houses. The most impressive are the four survivors of a row of nine wide houses—Nos. 5, 7, 9, and 17—each of which has a full-height curving bay on its front facade, an extremely rare feature in New York. In 1930 the family-planning pioneer Margaret Sanger moved her Birth Control Clinical Research Bureau into No. 17. Nos. 19 and 21 are simpler houses displaying fine ironwork, while No. 23 has a magnificent cast-iron balcony and stoop railing. All the houses have wide stone entrance enframements with battered sides and eared corners; this is a classic Greek form copied from the window surrounds on Greek temples.

197 **Lincoln Building, 1–3 Union Square West** (R. H. Robertson, 1889–90), designated 1988. The Lincoln Building is representative of the early skyscraper form as it evolved in New York, where architects chose to adapt already-popular styles to this new building type. Robertson designed the Lincoln Building in the same Romanesque Revival style that he used for churches, houses, and other structures. The building, faced in limestone, granite, red brick, and terra cotta, marks an important transitional phase in skyscraper engineering: it was constructed with a metal framing in combination with traditional masonry bearing walls.

198 **Bank of the Metropolis, 31 Union Square West** (Bruce Price, 1902–03), designated 1988. Price was an important early skyscraper designer with a particular interest in adapting the tripartite form of the column to tall buildings. This neo-Renaissance limestone-faced example is clearly massed in Price's preferred base-shaft-capital manner. The Bank of the Metropolis, founded in 1871 to serve the needs of businesses in the Union Square area, maintained its offices on the square until 1918, when it was absorbed by the Bank of Manhattan.

199 **Decker Building, now the Union Building, 33 Union Square West** (John Edelmann in the employ of Alfred Zucker, 1892–93), designated 1988. A rare example of a Moorish-inspired skyscraper, the headquarters of the

Decker Piano Company was designed by John Edelmann, mentor and friend of Louis Sullivan. Many features of the Decker Building, most notably the naturalistic ornament, reflect Sullivan's influence. Between 1968 and 1974 Andy Warhol's Factory occupied the sixth floor. The base was handsomely restored in 1995.

200 **Century Building, now Barnes & Noble Bookstore, 33 East 17th Street** (William Schickel, 1880–81), designated 1986. The red brick Century Building is a rare New York example of a Queen Anne-style commercial structure. Erected to house the prestigious Century Publishing Company, publisher of *The Century* and *St. Nicholas* magazines, the building is characteristic of the finest Queen Anne design in its free use of classical motifs in stone and terra cotta and its employment of the style's trademark sunflowers. After standing vacant for many years, the building was converted into a bookstore, and the facade received an award-winning restoration.

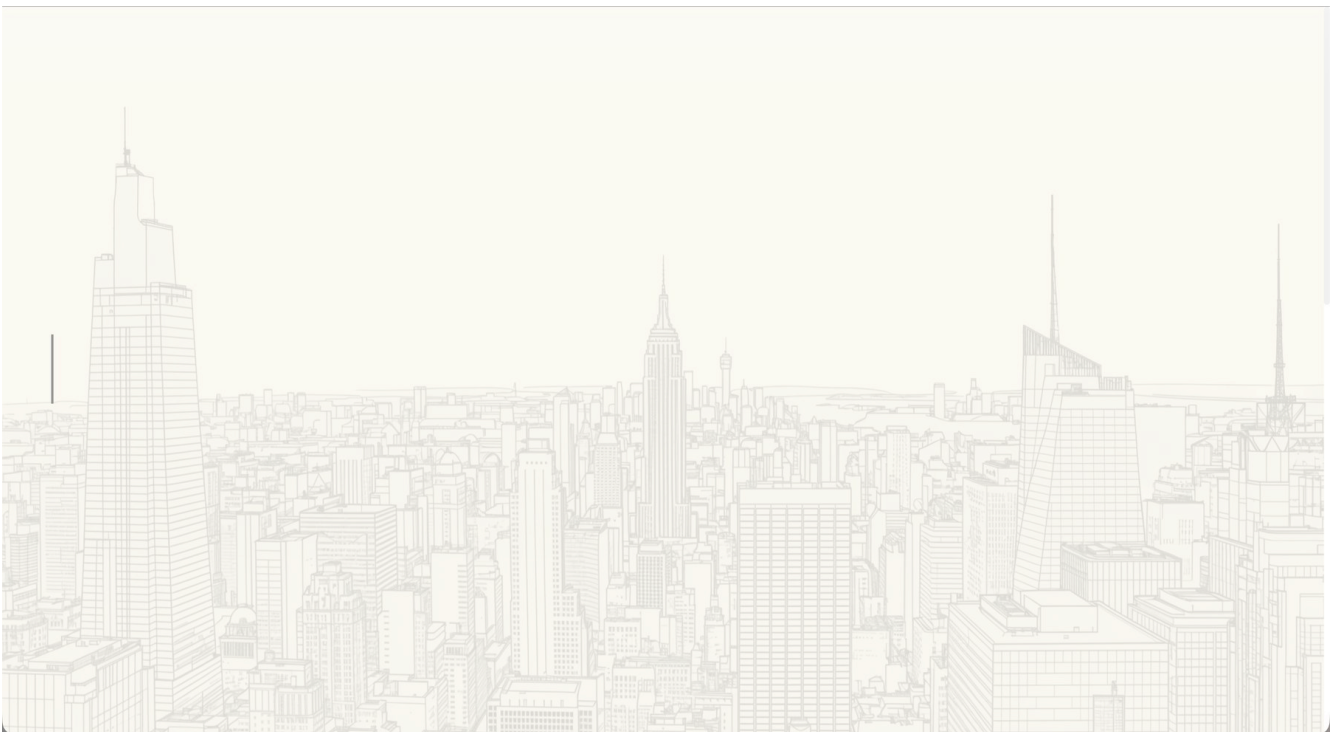
201 **Everett Building, 200 Park Avenue South** (Goldwin Starrett & Van Vleck, 1908), designated 1988. Located on the north side of Union Square, the Everett Building exemplifies an important development in the design of commercial high-rise buildings—the construction of functional, fireproof structures with large windows, open floor space, and simple classical detail. This emphasis on functionalism reflects the influence of Chicago skyscraper designs; in fact, the architect, Goldwin Starrett, had worked for four years in the Chicago office of Daniel Burnham.

202 **Gorham Manufacturing Company Building, 809–891 Broadway** (Edward Hale Kendall, 1883–84; alteration, John H. Duncan, 1912), designated 1984. This commercial building in the Queen Anne style was erected for the Gorham Manufacturing Company, a leading American silver firm, for its retail outlet in the exclusive Ladies' Mile shopping district. The Gorham is an early example of a mixed-use building: only the lower two floors were occupied by the store; the upper floors were rented as bachelor apartments. By 1893, however, the building was entirely in commercial use. The architect John H. Duncan is responsible for a remodeling of the building in 1912 that entailed the removal of a corner tower and the addition of roof dormers. The building now contains shops at street level and apartments above.

203 **Lord & Taylor Store, 901 Broadway** (James H. Giles, 1869–70), designated 1977. Two English immigrants, Samuel Lord and George Taylor, founded the dry goods firm

Morrone, *Architectural Guidebook*, 1994, p. 116

Quotes drawn from this page: 43 48 49



14th and 15th streets. Designed by Davis, Brody & Associates and built in 1987, this massive apartment and office complex represents the most strenuous effort to date to gentrify the neighborhood. The basic ungentrifiability of Union Square, however, is verified by the fact that Zeckendorf Towers turns its back on the square and places its main entrance around the block on the relatively tranquil and attractive Irving Place. The quartet of illuminated pyramids that top Zeckendorf Towers have become a conspicuous skyline feature, and sadly block the uptown view of the lighted clock face of the **Consolidated Edison Building** across the street at Four Irving Place, an ill-proportioned, but finely detailed, neoclassical base (1915, Henry J. Hardenbergh), surmounted by an ill-proportioned, but finely detailed, neoclassical tower (1926, Warren and Wetmore) which bears the clock.

At 20 Union Square East (Park Avenue South), at the northeast corner of 15th Street, is the **American Savings Bank**, designed by Henry Bacon and built in 1907. This is a compact building with an incredibly stately porch with four massive Corinthian columns. It is the only major building in New York by Bacon, who designed the Lincoln Memorial (1922) in Washington, D.C., and who was one of America's finest classical architects. At 201 Park Avenue South, at the northeast corner of 17th Street, is the **Guardian Life Insurance Building** of 1911, by D'Oench & Yost. It is a brooding, mansarded affair, exactly the kind of building that should be constructed to wall a square such as Union. Appended to it, at 105 East 17th Street between Park Avenue South and Irving Place, is a Miesian modern annex dating from 1961 and designed by Skidmore, Owings & Merrill.

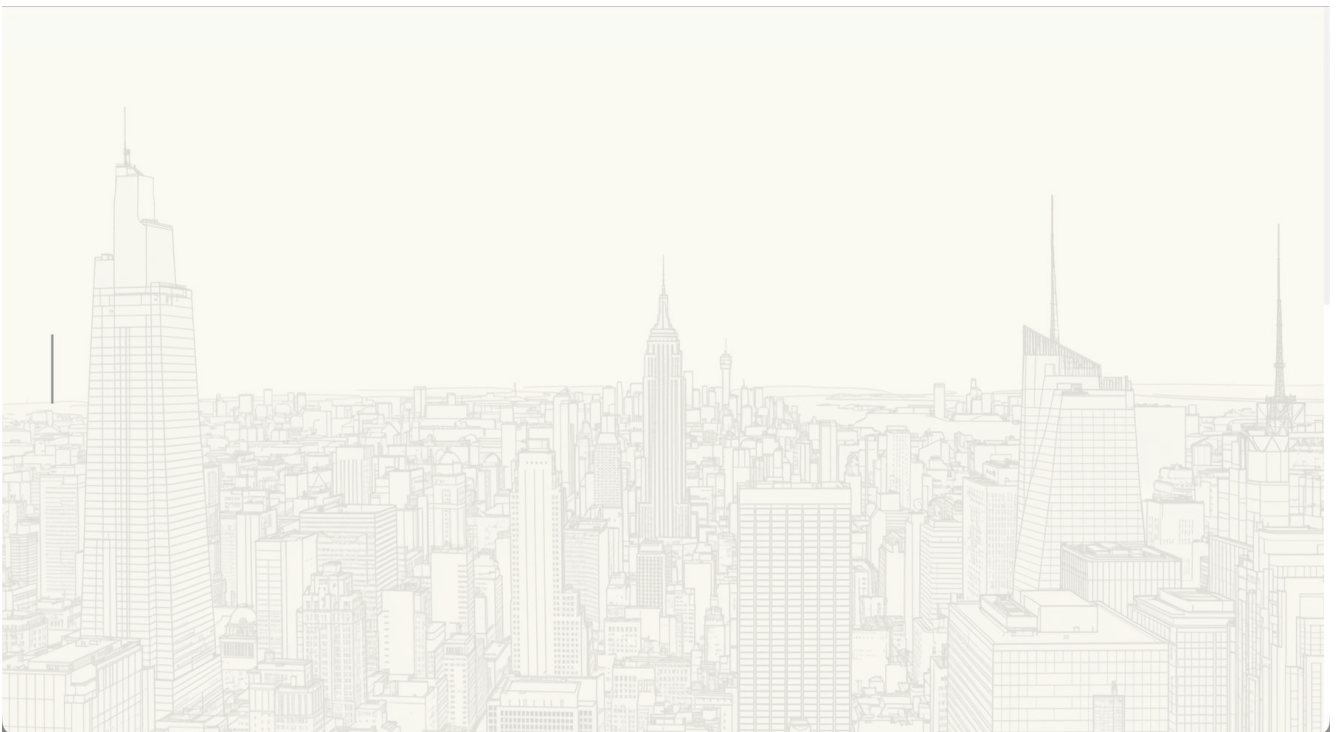
The Century Building, former headquarters of one of the most popular magazines of the nineteenth century, stands at 33 East 17th Street between Park Avenue South and Broadway. Built in 1881 and designed by William Schickel, this red-brick-and-limestone Queen Anne pile comes straight out of Victorian London. It is one of the few extant major Queen Anne buildings in Manhattan; see also the Gramercy apartments (1883, G. W. da Cunha, 8.7) at Gramercy Park, and the former Mercantile Exchange (1884, Thomas R. Jackson, 3.12) in TriBeCa. The former **Bank of the**



Metropolis, designed by Bruce Price, at 31 Union Square West, at the northwest corner of 16th Street, was built in 1903 and is another gem from the perhaps underrated father of Emily Post. Its Union Square

LPC, *Union Square*, 1903, p. 1

Quotes drawn from this page: 44 45



"<Architecture Style>_neo-Renaissance, <Base Color>_Coral Reef - 195 185 154, <Façade Color>_Pearl White - 238 235 218, <Base Material>_Rusticated Limestone, Granite Bulkheads, Polished Granite Columns, <Façade Material>_Limestone, <Entrance Description>_3-Bays, 2-Story Bowed Portico, Granite Ionic Columns, Lions' Heads, Console Brackets, Foliated Spandrels, Broken Pediment, Lion-head Waterspouts, Frieze, <Window Detail>_Square-headed, Stone Surround (3), Foliated Spandrels: Acanthus/ Roundel Centers (Rest), Open-mouthed Lions (10), <Brickwork Style>_Rusticated Pilasters, Round Headed Arches, Smooth Faced Pilasters, Swags, Egg & Dart Echinus, Tripartite Typology, <Roofline Description>_Scrolled Consoles, Wave/ 'Running Dog', Projecting Bandcourse, Palmettes, Copper Cornice, Dentils, Modillions."

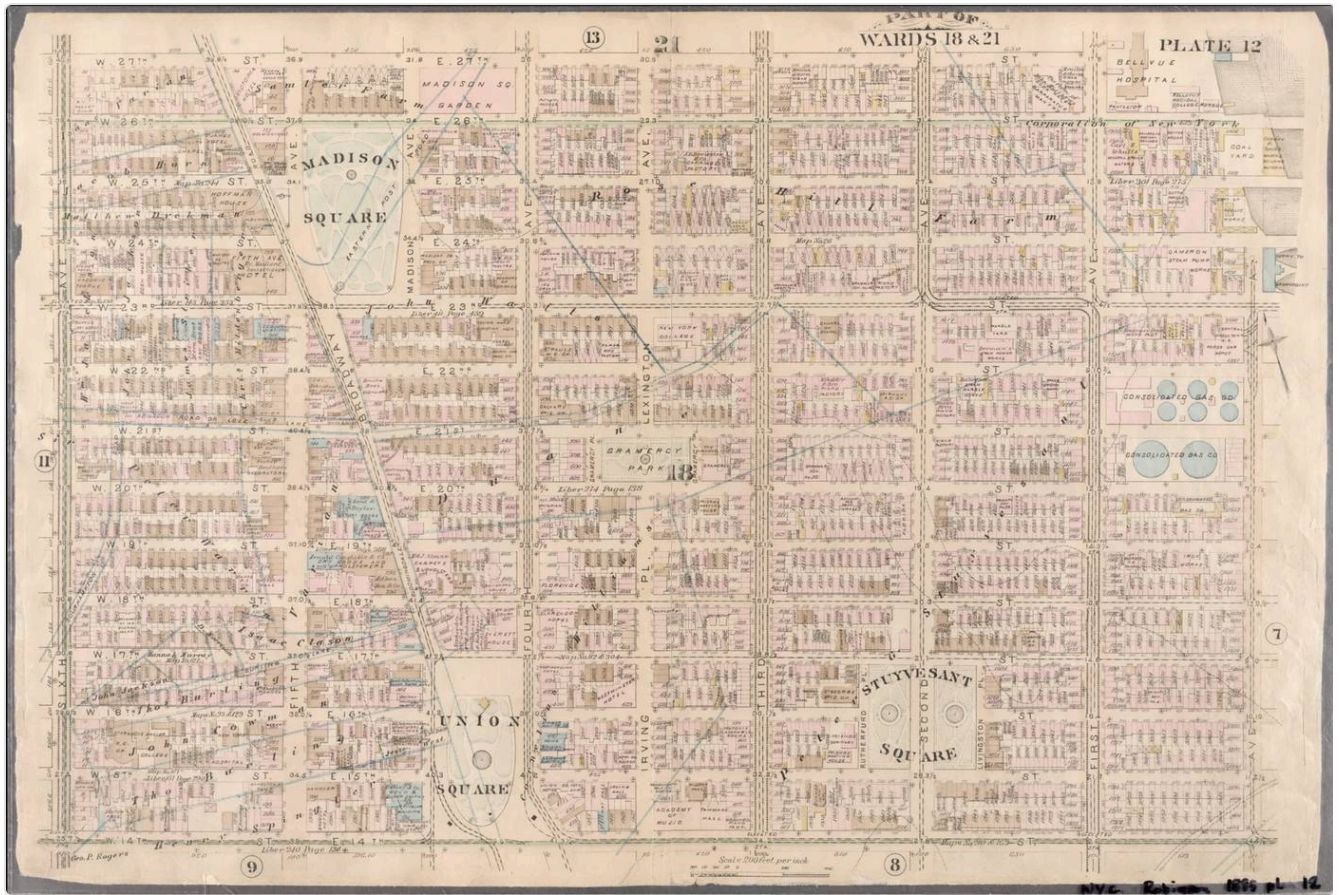
LPC · (1903) UNION SQUARE · 1903 · P. 1

Mentioned as: "31 Union Square West"

[View Document Image](#)

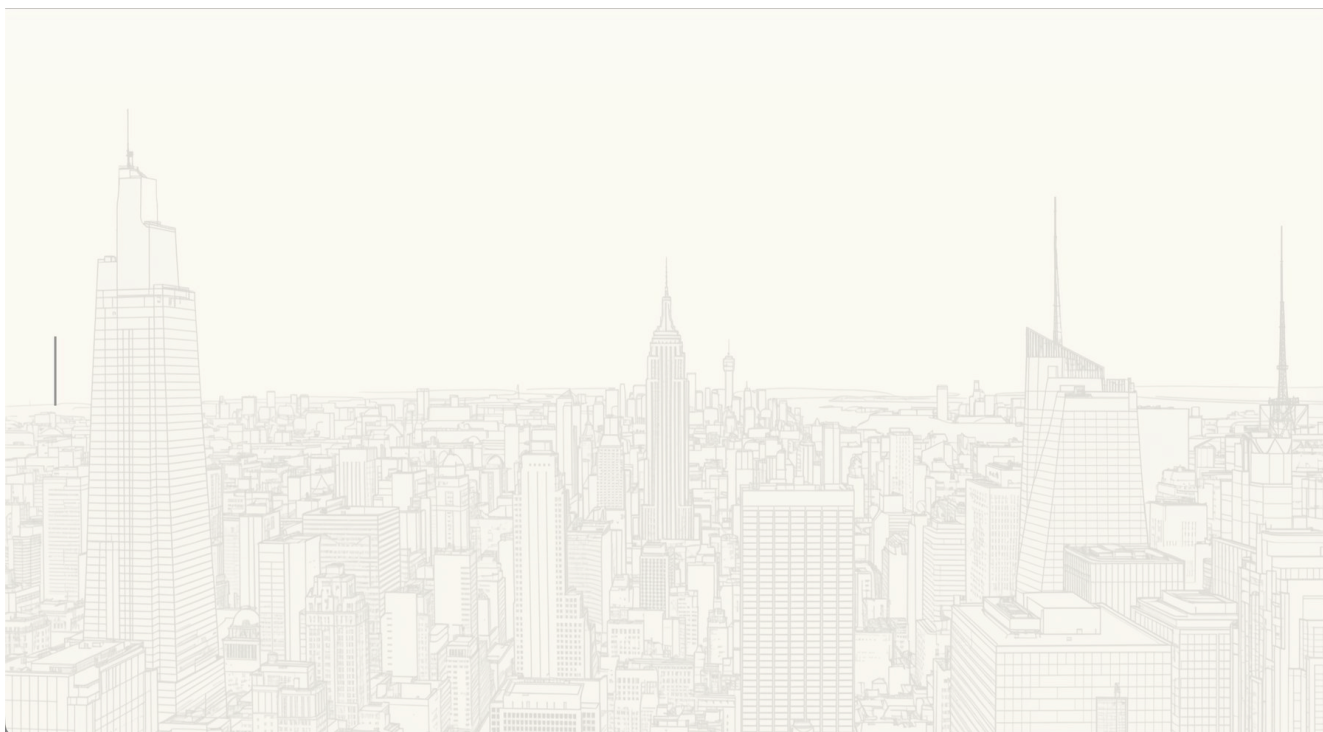
Robinson, 1885 Robinsons Atlas, p. 15

Quotes drawn from this page: 46 · Sheet supplied is Plate 12 (Wards 18 & 21); the citation records p. 15.



Wolfe, *New York 15 Walking Tours*, 2003, p. 249

Quotes drawn from this page: 47 50



A STROLL AROUND UNION SQUARE

Union Square Park has recently undergone a complete renovation. It has now become one of the favored recreational and meeting places for the local community, as well as for countless visitors who enjoy its new landscaping and upgraded facilities. As mentioned earlier, the name derives neither from any Civil War reference nor from association with union labor activities; rather, it was the "union" or place of connection in the early 19th century between the Bowery Road and Bloomingdale Road (now Broadway). As the city grew northward, the better residential districts followed, and the Park was fenced in. Then came the theater district, whereupon the residents soon fled, and the area boasted many theatrical and entertainment centers. As they, too, followed the crowd uptown, the Park became the favored venue for union demonstrations and political rallies, and the annual May Day celebration attracted millions. Union Square Park became, in effect, New York's version of London's Hyde Park. In the 1960s and '70s, the Park fell victim to neglect, indifference, and a proliferation of drug dealers. In a concerted effort to take back the Park, local business and community groups banded together in 1987 with a number of municipal and private agencies, including the Department of Parks & Recreation, to plan a major redesign and renovation—a prodigious project that was not completed until 2002.

The tour around Union Square begins at the northwest corner and goes clockwise around the Square.

At the northwest corner, a highly popular **Greenmarket** is held four times a week, with farmers bringing fresh vegetables, fruits, and baked goods from as far as 100 miles away. The Greenmarket idea was conceived of by architect-planner Barry Benepe. To the east of the market and connected to the classical park pavilion is Café Luna, a pleasant and popular outdoor café/restaurant.

Directly across the street is the **former Century Building, 33 East 17th Street**, now a **Barnes & Noble superstore** (William Schickel, 1880). The red brick, Queen Anne-style structure is one of the finest examples of the style and was built to house the many publishing activities of the Century Company. Among its imprints were the *Century* and *St. Nicholas* magazines and a host of fine books. It joined with D. Appleton & Company in 1933 and, after another merger, became Appleton-Century-Crofts.

The adjacent **Everett Building, 200 Park Avenue South** (Goldwin Starrett & Van Vleck, 1908), was designed in simple classical terms and is an important link in the development of the high-rise commercial building through its use of open floor space, large windows, and fireproofing. Its functional simplicity can be attributed to the influence of famed Chicago architect Daniel Burnham, for whom Starrett had worked for several years.

On the northeast corner of Park Avenue stands the former Guardian Life Insurance Company Building, now the **W New York Hotel, 201 Park Avenue South** (D'Oench & Yost, 1910). A magnificent presence on the Square for decades with its tall illuminated namesake sign above a towering mansard roof, it was a

Reiss, *New York Then and Now*, 2019, p. 76

Quotes drawn from this page: 51



1903

845

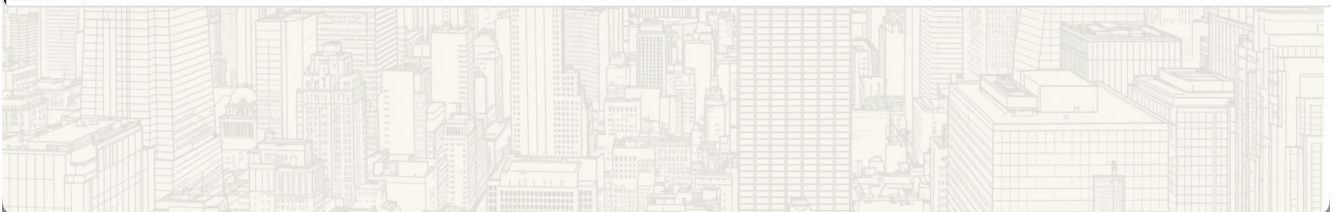
UNION SQUARE NORTH

Generations of flower vendors have flocked to the square

ABOVE: Although fashionable townhouses surrounded Union Square in the mid-nineteenth century, by the time of this photo, the neighborhood had been a bustling commercial and entertainment center for

several decades. The activity made Union Square a good place to do business, especially in holiday seasons, when the Easter flower market shown here was a popular attraction. The large building in

the background is the Century Company Building. Completed in 1881 on the north end of the square, it was first leased to the publishers of the popular *Century* and *St. Nicholas* magazines.



Stern, *New York* 2000, 2006, p. 377

Quotes drawn from this page: 52 57 64



a move that was rigorously opposed by the Union Square Community Coalition, a group largely made up of newer residents who had moved into lofts and apartments and feared the impact of real estate speculation on their rented homes. Efforts to rezone Zeckendorf's site coincided with a broader reassessment of the area's zoning, which had been studied in 1979–80 by Hardy Holzman Pfeiffer Associates. Those recommendations formed the basis, in 1984, of the Department of City Planning's proposed special zoning district, intended to encourage mixed-use development on underutilized sites in the park's vicinity, especially Zeckendorf's proposed one-million-square-foot project.¹⁹ Both the district and the Zeckendorf proposal for a twenty-six-story project were approved by the City Planning Commission in November 1984 and by the Board of Estimate in January 1985.²⁰ Concerns about the fate of historic buildings on other sites around the square led to the designation as landmarks of the Lincoln Building (R. H. Robertson, 1890), 1–3 Union Square West; the Bank of the Metropolis (Bruce Price, 1903), 31 Union Square West; the Century Building (William Schickel, 1881), 33 East Seventeenth Street; the Everett Building (Starrett & Van Vleck, 1908), 45 East Seventeenth Street; and the Germania Life Insurance Company Building (D'Oench & Yost, 1911), later the Guardian Life Building, 50 Union Square East.²¹

As built, the four twenty-story towers of Zeckendorf's project, unimaginatively titled Zeckendorf Towers, contained 670 condominium apartments rising above a seven-story base housing 320,000 square feet of offices, an atrium, a much-appreciated supermarket, theaters, and underground parking. Though banal in their detailed design, the scheme of slender, salmon-colored brick-clad towers, each topped by an open-work pyramidal crown—dismissed by the editors of the *AIA Guide* as “illuminated levitating . . . yarmulkes”—minimized shadows on the square and blockage of views from it to the tower of the Consolidated Gas Company Building (Warren & Wetmore, 1926), which they were intended to complement.²² The office floors were entered from Fourth Avenue facing Union Square Park, while the apartments were entered off Fifteenth Street. In its bland uniformity and lock-step regularity, Zeckendorf Towers was hardly inspiring, but it did help the reemerging district turn the economic corner.

While most new construction in the area involved demolition of existing buildings, a through-block parcel that had been vacant since the early 1970s permitted the construction of the twelve-story Genesis Apartments (1995) for ninety-four homeless and low-income families at 113 East Thirteenth Street and an attendant 30,000-square-foot, two-story commercial building at 114 East Fourteenth Street.²³ The project was developed by Housing Enterprise for the Less Privileged (H.E.L.P.), a nonprofit organization founded by Andrew Cuomo, son of New York State Governor Mario Cuomo. As designed by Cooper, Robertson & Partners, the quietly contextual apartment building eschewed all outward signs of social engineering in favor of an expression that many would assume was intended for a much more affluent clientele. Additionally, the building's management program included a program-services staff of fifteen to help the homeless tenants, whose stay was limited to twelve months, make an adjustment back into mainstream society. Genesis provided playgrounds, a day-care center, a basketball court, a library, and a laundry room. Although many in the community were initially opposed to the project, it proved an excellent neighbor.

The retail building on Fourteenth Street, however, was not comparable in quality; its low height, a product of zoning restrictions, contributed to its suburban strip-mall character.

1 Union Square South (1998), designed by Davis, Brody & Associates in association with Schuman, Lichtenstein, Claman & Efron, a twenty-seven-story, 180-unit apartment building atop an eighty-five-foot-high mixed-use retail base that included a fourteen-screen theater, occupied the highly visible 47,500-square-foot full-block site bounded by Fourth Avenue, Thirteenth Street, Broadway, and Fourteenth Street.²⁴ In 1995 the Related Companies had acquired the site from another developer who had cleared it of its buildings, including the historic Union Square Theater (1871; rebuilt, John Terhune and Leopold Eidlitz, 1889), 58 East Fourteenth Street, which had long been obscured behind a huge McDonald's sign.²⁵

Responding to community concerns that this most prominent site might yield yet another business-as-usual apartment house banality, the developers entered into an agreement with the Municipal Art Society to select an architectural firm that would maximize the site's most important attributes, its axial relationship to the vista south along Park Avenue from Grand Central Terminal and its prominent location at the edge of Union Square Park. The society asked two dozen architects to name a firm, besides their own, that they would recommend for the job. From the responses, Related chose three firms to participate in a competition held in 1995: Davis, Brody & Associates, Robert A. M. Stern Architects, and Hardy Holzman Pfeiffer Associates, which later withdrew. Stern proposed an eighteen-story tower on a five-story stone-clad site-filling retail base. The metal-trimmed brick-clad tower was to be set back from the property line to create a strong south terminus for Park Avenue, recalling the campanile-like configuration of Warren & Wetmore's New York Central Building (1929), which, until the construction of the Pan Am Building in 1963, had concluded the axis of Park Avenue on the north side of Grand Central.

Davis, Brody's winning scheme, designed by Steven Davis, son of founding partner Lewis Davis, sought to merge the base with the tower. The initial rendering revealed stylish asymmetrical patterns of windows as well as a deep balcony cut into the north wall. But as built, its blocky mass was pretty banal, the cut reduced to virtual inconsequence, leaving the heavy aesthetic lifting to the work of the artists Kristin Jones and Andrew Ginzel. In a separate competition organized by the Public Art Fund, the two had been chosen to embellish a 100-by-60-foot wall on the building's north facade, between the commercial base and the tower. Jones and Ginzel proposed *Metronome*, confronting the street with a brick wall overlaid with an undulating wavelike pattern of concentric circles and a so-called eye, a four-foot-in-diameter opening that emitted clouds of steam, clearly upstaging the rather tepid facade of the host building. The steam, intended by the artists to recall the geothermal outpouring of Old Faithful, poured forward twice a day, at noon and at midnight, as part of the artists' intention to examine time itself. Each emission was enhanced by the sounding of a long, tapered horn intended to echo the passage of time. A digital clock on the left side of the wall augmented the frequent movements of the city by simultaneously counting and subtracting the hours of the day, with the converging digits in the middle absorbed by a blur of activity, intended to suggest the present.

LPC, *Union Square*, 1881, p. 1

Quotes drawn from this page: 53 54 55 56

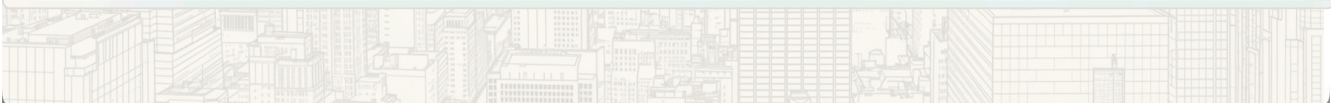


"<Architecture Style>_Queen-Anne, neo-Grec: Secondary Façade 18th Street, <Base Color>_Crystal - 213 213 213, <Façade Color>_Brick Red - 196 47 69, <Base Material>_Red Brick, Wyoming Bluestone, <Façade Material>_Brick, Terra Cotta, Wyoming Bluestone, Iron, <Entrance Description>_3 Bays, Pedimented, Arched, Fanlight, Cast Iron Ornament, Tuscan Pilasters, Console Bracket Capital, <Window Detail>_Segmental Arch Lintel (3-5), Stone Keystone, 2-story Oriel, Window Panes: [1/1] (w/ Transom), <Brickwork Style>_Running Bond, Rusticated Brick Pilasters, Garlands, Shells, Grotesques, Dentil Course, Egg & Dart Course, Swags, <Roofline Description>_Gambrel Roof, Cast Iron Cornice, 2-Story Dormers, Balustrade, Dentils, Frieze, Skew Corbels, Sunflower Terra Cotta Finials."

LPC · (1881) UNION SQUARE · 1881 · P. 1

Mentioned as: "33 East 17th Street"

[View Document Image](#)



Quotes drawn from this page: 62



Fourth Avenue, Looking North from East 17th Street (1901)

846.1

846.2

The buildings on the left are facing the northeast corner of Union Square, which in 1901 was a pleasant park, not a popular place for outdoor protest meetings. The five-story building at the northwest corner of East 17th Street is the Everett House. Built in 1854, this hotel was convenient to 14th Street's shopping, musical and theatrical attractions. The Everett particularly attracted theatrical and professional people. To the left is the Century Building, the home of both the *Century* magazine, an outstanding literary publication,

and the *St. Nicholas* magazine, the distinguished and popular publication for young people. The narrow 11-story office building at the far left is the Jackson Building. Behind the hotel, on the right, is the Bradley office building. The 13-story structure at the 19th Street corner houses the complete color-printing plant of the American Lithographic Company. The food vendor's cart alongside the Everett House is similar to those in use in New York today.

Dolkart, *Gramercy*, 1996, p. 78

Quotes drawn from this page: 65 66 67 68





NOS. 100-102 EAST 17TH STREET
Former Tammany Hall

On the southeast corner of East 17th Street and Union Square East, at 100-102 East 17th Street, stands the second of the district's institutional buildings, **Tammany Hall**, once the headquarters of New York City's Democratic Party political machine. Late in 1927, the Society of Tammany sold its headquarters on East 14th Street and announced the construction of a new Tammany Hall. Plans for the new building were made public in January 1928.⁵⁰ The building, designed by Thompson, Holmes & Converse and Charles B. Meyers, was to be a Colonial Revival structure built of red Harvard brick with granite trim (limestone was later substituted). The *Real Estate Record* described the design as "a dignified architectural treatment, one of the chief motifs of which are the severe Colonial columns in the centers of the Union Square and the Seventeenth-street facades which recall the days of early American architecture."⁵¹

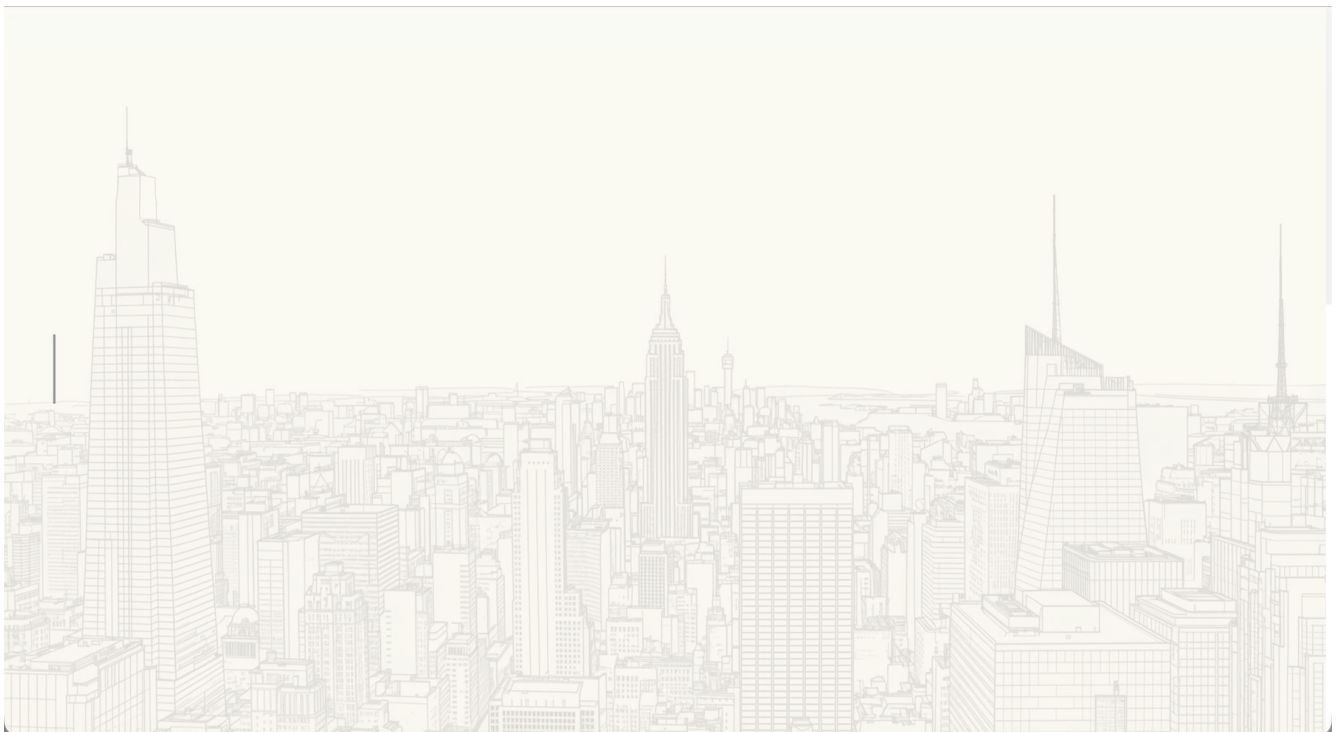
The Colonial Revival was undoubtedly chosen not only because it was reminiscent of the architecture of the early republic, but also because it symbolized the government established during that period. The Society of Tammany was attempting to associate itself with the ideals of early American democracy; in fact, the Union Square facade bears a striking resemblance to the original Federal Hall, where George Washington took the oath of office as the first President of the United States. By choosing the Colonial Revival style, with all that it symbolized, Tammany may have been attempting to create the image of a truly democratic force to counter the accusations that it was a corrupt political machine.

50. "Architects Picked for Tammany Hall," *New York Times*, January 18, 1928, p. 52; "New Tammany Hall Will Be Colonial in Design," *Real Estate Record and Builders Guide* 121 (January 28, 1928), p. 7. The *Real Estate Record* article includes an elevation drawing. A slightly different elevation drawing, closer to the building as actually constructed, was illustrated in the Architectural League's *Yearbook* (1929), n.p.

51. "New Tammany Hall..."

Spielvogel, *The Landmarks of New York*, 2016, p. 679

Quotes drawn from this page: 69 70





NEW YORK FILM ACADEMY

**NEW YORK FILM ACADEMY, FORMERLY
ROUNABOUT THEATRE; LOCAL 91 OF
ILGWU; TAMMANY HALL**

1928–29; 1943; 1984; 1991; 1994;
2001; 2005

100 EAST 17TH STREET, (AKA 100–102
EAST 17TH STREET, 44–48 UNION
SQUARE, 44–48 UNION SQUARE EAST),
MANHATTAN.

ARCHITECTS: THOMPSON, HOLMES &
CONVERSE AND CHARLES B. MEYERS

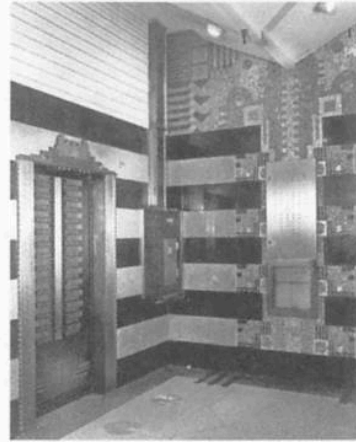
DESIGNATED: OCTOBER 29, 2013

Tammany Hall, now a byword for municipal corruption, once dominated the City's political arena. An outgrowth of the eighteenth-century Tammany Society, Tammany Hall quickly became affiliated with the newly formed Democratic Party, promoting public education, universal suffrage for white males, and helping to abolish debtors' prisons; as well as providing support for newly arrived Irish, French, and German immigrants. By the mid-nineteenth century, Tammany was firmly in charge of the municipal government, and under the leadership of the now infamous "Boss" William Tweed. His fall, and the emergence of a "New Tammany" in the

1920s, refashioned as a "good government" organization, has been identified by some as the impetus for the construction of this New Tammany Hall, the only surviving headquarters building of Tammany.

This distinguished neo-Georgian façade, with its rusticated stone base, double-height pilasters, and sculptural reliefs in terra cotta and limestone, was inspired by the original Federal Hall (demolished 1812) on Wall Street, where the first President of the United States, George Washington, took his oath of office. Clad with specially molded and oversized brick laid in Flemish bond, other neo-Georgian elements of the façade, such as the blind arches that frame the multilight sash windows, the fanlight transoms, wrought iron balconies, and semicircular attic window, deliberately evoke the dignity of early American architecture.

In 1929, when the building was completed, Tammany had again fallen out of favor, and by 1943, the Society sold the building to Local 91 of the International Ladies Garment Workers Union, which occupied it until 1984. That year, the Local entered into a lease agreement with the Roundabout Theatre, which renovated and occupied the building's auditorium until 1991, when it moved to 45th Street. Local 91 subsequently leased the auditorium to producer Raymond L. Gaspard, and then to the owners of Minetta Lane Theatre. In 1994, the Local began leasing portions of the building not occupied by the theater to the New York Film Academy; in 2001, the entire building was sold to Liberty Theatres



FILM CENTER BUILDING INTERIOR

and four years later the air rights were conveyed to US Development LLC.

FILM CENTER BUILDING INTERIOR

1928–29

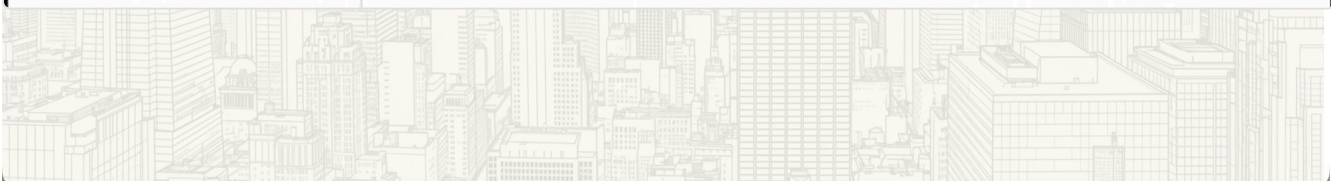
630 NINTH AVENUE, MANHATTAN

ARCHITECT: ELY JACQUES KAHN

DESIGNATED: NOVEMBER 9, 1982

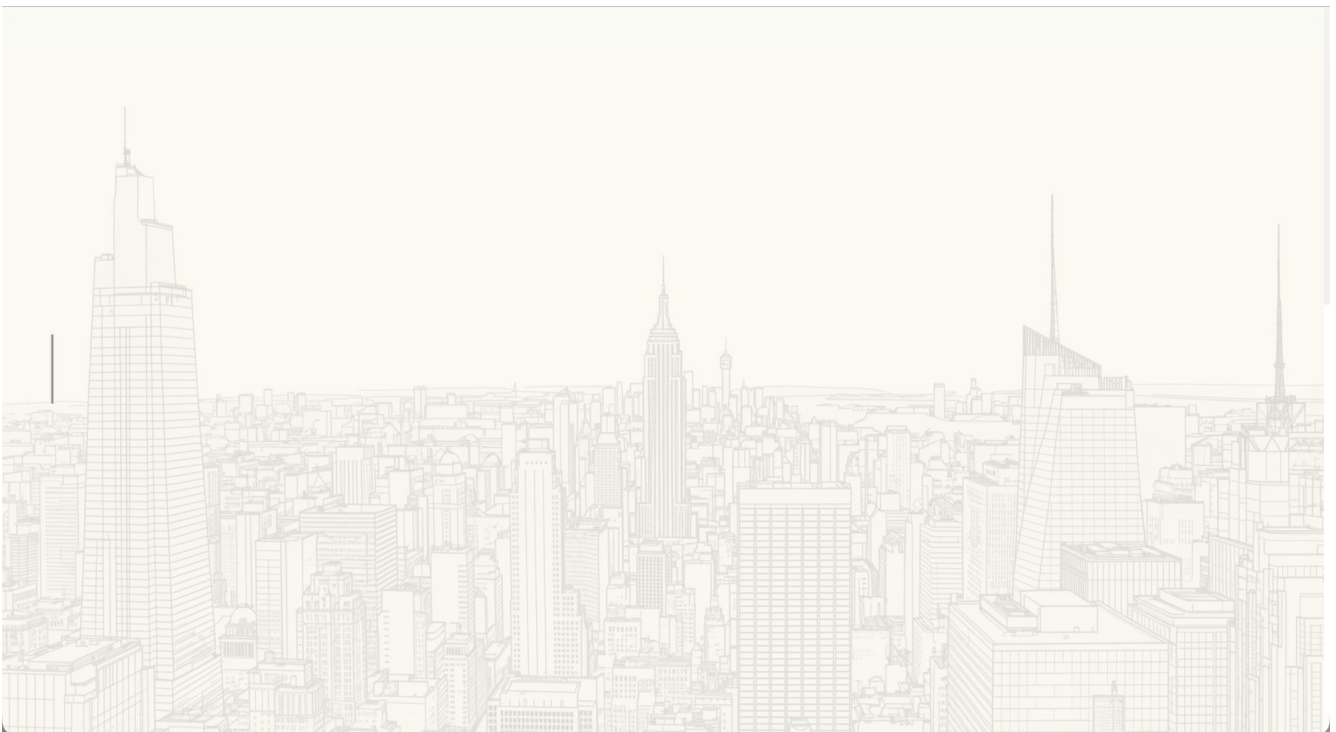
The Film Center Building's interiors are among the most colorful and inventive surviving Art Deco ensembles in New York City. Walls and ceilings are treated as woven plaster tapestries, a motif frequently employed by architect Ely Jacques Kahn. He may have been influenced by Frank Lloyd Wright's California textile block houses, which were built in the mid-1920s; both architects shared an interest in Mayan architecture, which seems evident in their work.

In the outer vestibule, an ornamental plaster band runs across the ceiling and



Kahn, *City Secrets New York City*, 2002, p. 189

Quotes drawn from this page: 74



I love the “necklace” formed by Union Square, Gramercy, and Madison Square parks so much that I have chosen to conduct my entire personal and professional life around those jewels. It’s Manhattan at its most civilized scale, and no neighborhood better combines beautifully preserved historic architecture with a dynamic sense of modern style. One could say that this is where “Ladies’ Mile” meets “Silicon Alley.” Architects, publishers, and new-media executives commingle with young family residents, green-market farmers, and the city’s densest population of excellent restaurants. The trick to any stroll through this zone is to look up. Each building brings an animated story to the streetscape, and many have been lovingly restored and given meaningful, modern uses. The Union Square Greenmarket—open Monday, Wednesday, Friday, and Saturday, but at its abundant and bustling best on Wednesday and Saturday—is New York’s closest thing to a vital Italian piazza. It is perhaps the only place in the city where New Yorkers choose to slow down, smell the smells, and talk to each other.



DANNY MEYER

Restaurateur and cookbook author

RECOMMENDED READING

Joyce Mendelsohn, *Touring the Flatiron: Walks in Four Historic Neighborhoods*, New York Landmarks Conservancy, 1998.

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ADAM GLICK

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